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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PM PRACHANDA, UML CHAIR OLI HOLD MEETING

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' held a meeting with CPN (UML) Chairperson, KP Sharma Oli, with an objective of making the Parliament upcoming session effective.

During the meeting held at the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers today, they discussed various issues, including completing the remaining task of the peace process and the bill related to transitional justice, said PM Prachanda's press advisor Govinda Acharya.

The winter session of both houses of the Federal Parliament is commencing from February 5.

MORE MAY BE ARRESTED IN BANSBARI CASE: CIB

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

The Central Investigation Bureau (CIB) of Nepal Police has clarified that other persons may also be held for police investigation in the case related to the embezzlement of 10 ropanis of the land of Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory.

The CIB made this remark at a press conference held on Friday about the arrest of Arun Chaudhary, 60, Chairman and Managing Director of CG Holdings of CG Group, and Ajit Narayan Singh Thapa, 80, the former Executive Chief of Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory.

CIB Spokesperson and SP Nava Raj Adhikari said that it took three months for the CIB to complete the investigation into the Bansbari land-grabbing case.

"It took us more than three months to complete the investigation of this case", he said, "Its investigation will continue." As the investigation is on, other persons may also be arrested," said SP Adhikari.

He said that Thapa, former executive chief of the Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory, and Sanjay Thakur, 45, owner of Chandbagh School under CG Group, were also arrested. "During the investigation, others, no matter who they are may also be arrested if they are found involved in the embezzlement."

"Now, just two persons who gave the land and who bought the land were arrested for the investigation. More people may also be arrested later on," SP Adhikari said.

The land of the Factory has been in the government's registration since November 5, 1980, according to the land registration record book in the Land Registration Office, Dilli Bazaar, the CIB said.

"While selling the land to the CG Group, there had not been any political level and government level decision," said SP Adhikari.

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PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Two workers painting the entrance gate to Dharahara Tower in the capital on Friday. The monument is set to be open for public from Nepali New Year in mid-April.

National wetland policy lacks regulations

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Various programmes were organised in the country to commemorate World Wetlands Day which is celebrated on February 2 every year. However, experts have voiced concerns, stating that the significance of the day often remains limited to slogans without substantial action.

The National Wetland Policy was first formulated in 2002, followed by a second formulation in 2012. However, there remains a lack of corresponding legislation and regulations to effectively implement these policies. The experts have criticised the government for its inadequate efforts to conserve wetlands, particularly in the Tarai region and the Kathmandu Valley.

Despite the importance of wetlands for ecosystem restoration, marshes in Nepal are facing numerous threats and challenges, including urbanisation, agricultural expansion, pollution, invasive species and unsustainable resource extraction, said ornithologist Dr. Hem Sagar Baral.

According to Dr. Baral, wetlands are essential for a multitude of ecological, social, and economic benefits. They serve as habitats for diverse wildlife, including endangered species and play crucial roles in flood control, groundwater recharge, water purification, and climate regulation.

> Wetlands in the Kathmandu Valley, such as the Bagmati, Bishnumati, Taudaha, and Manohara rivers, along with various other rivers, are deteriorating due to the influx of human waste.

However, wetlands in the Kathmandu Valley, such as the Bagmati, Bishnumati, Taudaha, and Manohara rivers, along with various other rivers, are deteriorating due to the influx of human waste.

This year, the day was celebrated under the theme "Wetlands and Human Wellbeing," emphasising the significant contributions of wetlands to flood protection, clean water, biodiversity, and recreational opportunities, all of which are essential for human health and prosperity.

However, it is concerning that wetlands, which play a crucial role in providing water sources for human well-being, are being polluted, experts said.

Wetland expert Top Bahadur Khatri highlighted that wetlands in the Tarai region are being encroached upon, while high-altitude wetlands are expanding. Both situations pose risks to living beings and ecosystems.

"The rivers in the Kathmandu Valley are polluted due to anthropogenic activities, including the draining of underground water and pollution of rivers. Given this situation, it becomes challenging to sustain wetlands in urban areas," Khatri added.

However, he mentioned that there was no problem in the mid-hill areas.

There is a National Wetland Policy 2012, but the government has shown little concern about establishing its regulatory framework, he added. There should be an Act to provide the necessary support for the Policy, Khatri said.

Gobinda Pokharel, a conservation officer at the National Trust for Nature Conservation, expressed concern about the impact of concrete artificial ponds on the beauty of natural ponds. He said, "Many aquatic animals are disappearing because of the concrete ponds, as they require river banks to lay eggs and bask, but there is no space for that in the concrete ponds."

Dr. Baral remarked that the government's focus was primarily on the protected Ramsar sites, but it had not shown adequate concern for the wetlands within the capital valley.

Nepal boasts several Ramsar sites designated under the Ramsar Convention, signifying their international significance.

Notable wetlands among these include the Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve, Ghodaghodi Lake, Bis Hazari Tal, and Jagadishpur Reservoir.

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No one is free to plunder the state: DPM Shrestha

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Lekhnath, Feb. 2



Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has said that no one has the right and freedom to plunder the state under any pretext.

Addressing the Gandaki Province Level-Security Conference that began in Pokhara on Friday, the Deputy Prime Minister said that even though the political system has changed, the condition of the people has remained the same.

We need to overcome the challenges that impede good governance, said DPM Shrestha.

DPM Shrestha stressed the need to institutionalise the system obtained through great sacrifices and said that no one has the freedom to plunder the state.

DPM Shrestha said that nobody could be given a license to rob the state and this crime could not be overlooked anymore.

DPM Shrestha said, "The economic prosperity of the country is the main responsibility of the government. Likewise, the prosperity with social justice is the goal of the present government."

DPM Shrestha indicated that he had faced many obstacles in his endeavour to control corruption and maintain good governance.

"When any leader gets arrested, the parties start wailing, when there is an employee held for irregularity, the employees' organisations stage a protest, and when industrialists and businessmen are arrested, they start issuing press notes denouncing the arrests," DPM Shrestha said.

DPM Shrestha said that necessary commissions would be set up to complete the rest tasks of the peace process.

"Security and development should go hand in hand. Prosperity and order cannot be achieved by leaving the peace process incomplete," he said.

He said that recently the government had taken a new decision regarding the problem of cooperatives. He mentioned that solution measures would be adopted along with the amendment to the Cooperative Act. "We are immediately forming a body to regulate cooperatives," he added.

A meeting of the National Coordination Council is being held on February 7. After the meeting, the adjustment process of the federal police will begin, said DPM Shrestha.

In the programme, the Chief Minister of Gandaki Province, Surendra Raj Pandey, pointed out that the need to amend the law to get the right to spend the budget allocated by the province in the security sector.

The Federal government needs to abandon the centralised mentality, said Chief Minister Pandey.

The meeting which started on Friday will continue till Saturday. The heads of various security agencies, chief district officers of all 11 districts of Gandaki province and chiefs of the district police offices are participating in the meeting.

'Align policies with federal system'

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation, Shakti Bahadur Basnet, has pledged to formulate the policies and programmes for the upcoming fiscal year in a way that they will contribute to strengthen the federal system.

In his address to a meeting of a thematic committee concerning the energy, water resources and irrigation sector among the representatives from the federal, province and local governments on Friday, the Minister assured that the upcoming policies and programmes would address citizens' aspirations and needs. He also drew the attention of respective ministers in the province to avoid the duplication while selecting programmes.

As he informed, the government prioritizes expansion of irrigation facilities for the promotion of agricultural sectors and this should be reflected in the province and local policies and programmes.

Conclusion of under-construction projects is one of the special priorities of the federal government, he informed the meeting. According to him, 1 million hectares of land is yet to have access to irrigation.

Basnet stressed on the need of selecting projects which are most needed and specific to ensure benefits to the locals.

Minister for Minister for Water Resources and Energy (Karnali), Urmila BK, Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development (Sudur Pashim),

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Rato Machhindranath reconstruction in limbo

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Lalitpur, Feb. 2



Reconstruction of the much-awaited Shikhar-styled Rato Machhindranath temple in Bungamati, Lalitpur, has been left in limbo again since September 19, 2023, due to the lack of budget.

Also, the term of the Rato Machhindranath Temple Reconstruction Consumer's Committee has not been extended.

Earlier, the fate of the famous temple was pushed into uncertainty after the government of Sri Lanka withdrew its support for the temple reconstruction project because of controversies over the use of construction materials and other issues.

Thereafter, the government had given the responsibility of reconstructing the temple to the Rato Machhindranath Temple Reconstruction Consumer's Committee (RMTRCC), and the reconstruction works of the temple were being carried out by the Department of Archaeology.

"We have completed around 80 per cent of construction works. But the construction works have been stopped for the last four and a half months because of the financial crises and the term of the project was also not extended," said Amir Shakya, Chairman of the Consumers' Committee.

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Are juveniles permitted for Everest trek?

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Taking advantage of the absence of clear policy and procedures about taking children to high mountains of Nepal, a couple from Scotland took their 2-year old toddler to the Everest Base Camp (EBC) on October 25 last year.

Now the child, Carter Dallas, is catapulted to a celebrity status after British media carried the news about the feat on January 29 this year.

His news has been carried by numerous media in South Asia and around the world leaving the audience amazed.

Carter was taken to the EBC located at 17,598 feet above sea level by his parents Ross, 35, and Jade, 31.

The British media claimed that the toddler is considered as the youngest person ever to reach the EBC.

Earlier, a four-year old girl from Czech Republic was considered as the youngest person to reach the Base Camp. According to Czech Radio, four and a half years old girl Zara Sifra having Czech and Canadian dual citizenship, reached there on January 7 this year with her father and seven-year old brother, Alex.



A news report carried by The Telegraph quoted Ross as saying that the child coped better than his father and got no other problems other than slight altitude sickness.

However, the feat of the toddler has led to a debate as to what extent should juvenile trekkers or climbers should be allowed to go up.

It has drawn the attention of the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA), Department of Tourism, Trekking Agencies Association of Nepal (TAAN) and a couple of federal and provincial agencies working in the tourism sector.

They are mulling over the question – whether juveniles should be allowed to climb high mountains of Nepal.

According to the officials of the tourism ministries and departments, there is no any law or rule that sets age bar for a person to reach high altitude area including the base camps like EBC, Annapurna Base Camp and Kanchenjunga Base Camp.

They said that it seemed that the parents took the risk of taking their child to the EBC on their own. Experts also said that the altitude has varied impacts on the people from mountains, hills and plains.

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Gold import drops amid price hikes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Import of precious yellow metal has dropped significantly during the first half of the current fiscal year 2023/24. According to the statistics of the Department of Customs, the import of gold in terms of its value has decreased by 59 per cent during the first six months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year.

In the first six months of the current fiscal year 2023/24, about 1,424 kg of gold worth Rs. 11.88 billion was imported. The country imported 1,835 kg of gold worth Rs. 29.20 billion during the first six months of the last fiscal year. Gold worth Rs. 43 billion was imported in the fiscal year 2022/23.

The gold import decreased significantly in the first six months of the current fiscal year compared to the corresponding period of the previous fiscal year after the government reduced the gold import quota due to increasing pressure on foreign exchange reserves.

However, during the review period, the import of silver has increased. The country imported 21,224 kg of silver worth Rs. 2.1 billion during the first six months of the current fiscal year. This is 129 per cent higher than the corresponding period last fiscal year. About 10,443 kg of silver worth Rs. 919 million was imported during the first six months of the last fiscal year 2022/23.



The country spent Rs. 2.7 billion for the import of silver over the fiscal year 2022/23. The reduction of gold import quota for the local market and significant price hikes of gold have contributed to the decline in gold import in terms of value and quantity in the current fiscal year, said Tej Ratna Shakya, a gold trader and special member of Federation of Nepal Gold and Silver Dealers' Association.

The demand for gold has decreased in the local market due to price hikes of gold even in the wedding season. Even in the present wedding season, supply of 20 kg daily is enough to meet the demand, he said. The demand for gold was above 45 kgs daily during the wedding season last year.

The price of gold set a new record in the country a few days ago amid its soaring price internationally and the depreciation of Nepali rupees. The price of the precious yellow metal set a historic record when a tola of gold was traded at Rs. 122,000 in the domestic bullion market on December 28 last year. The price of gold was about Rs. 105,000 per tola last year.

He said that due to the increase in prices and reduction in the purchasing power of people, consumers used to reuse their old jewellery to meet their needs.

In the meantime, the export of gold jewellery also dropped by 78 per cent to Rs. 23 million during the review period as compared to the same period last fiscal year. Similarly, the export of silver jewellery decreased by 5.7 per cent to Rs. 87 million during the review period.

Cycle tour to promote tourism

RSS
Ranjha (Banke), Feb. 2

Cycle tour from Nepalgunj to Thakurdwara of Bardiya is to be organised to promote tourism in Banke and Bardiya. Nepalgunj Cycling Club is organising the cycle tour where around 300 cyclists would participate, according to Club Chairperson, Pradeep Sapkota.

'Tour De Thakurdwara' and Nepalgunj Kids Race' would be organised under the three-day Nepalgunj Cycle Festival from February 8. All the preparations for route for cycle tour have already been made and local cyclists along with inter-province cyclists and international cyclists would participate in the cycle tour, he added.

Former Chairperson of the Club, Satish Niraula, shared, "Our main objective is to carry out activities linking cycling with our culture and tourism. This programme will help to exert pressure for safe cycling in the area and expansion of cycle lane in city."

The main motto of the 'Tour De Thakurdwara' cycle tour is to protect tourism and culture in environment friendly manner. There would be also participation of cyclists from Indian cities in the cycle tour, added the Club.

The 100-kilometer tour will start from Bageshwori Temple of Nepalgunj to Thakurdwara of Bardiya National Park via different tourism sites of Banke and Bardiya districts, mentioned senior Vice-Chairperson of the Club, Surendradwip Karki.

29th CAN Infotech to start from Monday

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

The 29th edition of CAN Infotech – the largest exhibition and trade festival of information and technology-related business and innovations - will be held in the capital from February 8-12.

The Computer Association Nepal Federation (CAN Federation), the organiser of the event, informed that the CAN Infotech has been organised every year to exhibit new technologies developed in the field of information and communication technology and create meaningful interactions for the development of this sector.

The 'CAN Infotech 2024' is sponsored by S Power BPE Pvt. Ltd. and co-sponsored by HMC Dahua. It is supported by the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology, the Department of Information Technology, and private sector organisations like the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry. Asian-Oceanian Computing Industry Organization (ASOCIO), WITSA (World Innovation, Technology and Services Alliance) and Toa Software Corp have extended their support to this exhibition.

Stating that CAN Infotech will showcase the development and expansion of Nepal's technology sector, CAN Federation President Ranjit Poddar said that it would help in building Digital Nepal. "We are confident that the exhibition of the latest technology and the talents and innovations developed according to the demand of the local market will help the campaign of creating Digital Nepal," he said.

Similarly, General Secretary of the Federation, Chiranjivi Adhikari mentioned that special priority has been given to startups, young talent, innovation and Nepali products in CAN Infotech.

The tickets for the exhibition could be bought at Rs. 100 for the general public and Rs. 50 for students. There will be a free entry provision for senior citizens, differently-abled people and children aged below 10 years, while groups of students of government and community colleges can enter free of cost at the recommendation of their respective institutions. CAN Federation will announce a scholarship on IT education for this year in collaboration with Lord Buddha Education Foundation during the Infotech.

Similarly, Nepal Robotics Academy in collaboration with CAN Federation is scheduled to release the beta version of the generative AI system 'Kanchhi' robot developed in Nepal at the CAN Infotech. There will be a cyber security help desk at the exhibition which will be managed by NP Short and CSRI.

CAN Federation member organisations as well as various national and international information and communication technology companies will participate in the information and communication technology exhibition.

The organiser maintained that the exhibition will be used by businessmen as a platform for business expansion as well as a platform for exhibiting new technologies and observers will be able to view and purchase new and future technologies and equipment in information and communication technology at one platform.

"CAN Infotech will provide an unprecedented opportunity for companies in the information and communication technology sector to expand their market, understand customer needs, conduct market surveys, launch new products and establish mutual relationships with customers," said the CAN Federation.

Likewise, various interactive discussion programmes related to information technology will be organised throughout the Infotech period.

Branding, ICT accessories, product launching, IT career counselling, startup and innovation pavilion, and software pavilion have been arranged at the Infotech.

Priority will be given to products and solutions prepared through research and development in Nepal. Under this, free stalls have been arranged for Nepali startups for innovative and startup pavilions.

'KATAHO' digital address system developed by the company run by celebrated Nepali scientist Ram-Lakshman, will also be inaugurated at the Infotech.

Solar power generated in Jhapa connected to NEA substation

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Damak, Feb. 2

The voltage fluctuation problem in the surrounding areas was resolved after the 10-megawatt solar power project in Koshi Province was connected to the local substation of the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA).

The solar energy promoted by Jhapa Energy Limited produces up to 6 megawatts of electricity daily even in the winter season and it will produce 10 megawatts in summer.

Jhapa Energy Limited inaugurated the solar plant constructed in Shivasatakahsi Municipality-4, Jhapa amidst a function held on Thursday and informed about the works that have been accomplished so far. The project site is being developed as a tourist destination.

Lal Prasad Sanwa, Chairman of Jhapa Energy Limited, said that their idea of starting a solar energy project has become a reality, and it has aided the economic development of Jhapa district. Electricity generated from the project has already been connected to the Buluchowk substation of NEA, said Sanwa.

About 22 bighas of land required for the construction of the project were purchased in the name of Jhapa Energy Limited and Jhapa Agro Industries Pvt. Ltd. Sanwa said that the construction of a park to develop it as an energy tourism area has reached its final stage.

He said that after the official inauguration of the project, the primary shares will be issued to the affected locals. Former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli is scheduled to inaugurate the project officially on February 6, 2024.

Paritosh Chaudhary, the chief of Nepal Electricity Authority, Damak, said that after the project started generating solar energy, the problem of electricity in this area was resolved. The voltage fluctuation problem has disappeared to a significant level, and there is no problem with electricity in the local feeders, he added.

According to Chairman Sanwa, the total cost of the project is Rs. 850 million. Around 75 per cent of the investment is from the banks and the rest from local investors. The power purchase agreement of the project is for 25 years.

He said that the project is expected to generate 17.6 million units of electricity annually and its annual income is expected to be Rs. 128.5 million.

INDUSHANKAR PAYING FARMERS WITHIN WEEK

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Feb. 2

Indushankar Sugar Mills of Harion of Sarlahi district has started paying the farmers within a week of purchasing the sugarcane. The sugarcane farmers are happy after Indushankar, which has made a mark apart from other sugar industries by paying payments on time, has deposited money in the bank accounts of farmers within a week it purchased the canes.

Yog Narayan Rajak, sugarcane manager of Indushankar Sugar Mills, said that although the federation of sugarcane farmers had agreed to pay within 30 to 45 days, the industry was paying within a week. "It has been agreed with the Federation of Sugarcane Producers' Association, that 'payment' will be made within 30 to 45 days, but we are paying within a week," said Rajak.

According to the industry, it has pai2d around Rs. 526 million for the sugarcane purchased from the farmers by January 24, 2024. Thakur Nepal, administrative chief of the industry, said that a schedule has been prepared for the payment of an additional Rs. 144 million within two to three days.

According to the price determined by the government, the industry has been paying sugarcane farmers at the rate of Rs. 565 per quintal. This year, the price of sugarcane has been fixed at Rs. 635 per quintal, with sugar mills providing Rs. 565 per quintal and the government providing Rs. 70 as a subsidy.

Indushankar, which started crushing sugarcane on December 22, 2023, has crushed 1.42 million quintals of sugarcane by Monday this week. Rajak said that the industry has set a target of crushing 3.5 million quintals of sugarcane this year.

On the other hand, the Mahalaxmi Sugar Mills, Bagdah located in Godaita Municipality of Sarlahi has also crushed 806,000 quintals of sugarcane and paid about Rs. 300 million to the farmers, according to Kamalesh Singh, administrative assistant of the industry.

Devendra Yadav, Mayor of Godaita Municipality, who is also a sugarcane farmer, said that Mahalaxmi has not given any problem in payment so far this year. Similarly, the Annapurna Sugar Mills, Dhankaul of Sarlahi has not yet started operating mills.

Transport employees strike affects Germany

AP
Berlin, Feb. 2

Local buses, trams and subway trains were canceled in much of Germany on Friday as transport employees walked off the job in the country's third transport-related strike in two weeks.

The Ver.di service workers' union called for a "warning strike," a common tactic in German contract negotiations, on Monday. Its deputy chair, Christine Behle, said that "the time has now come to exert more pressure on employers" as talks on new pay contracts for about 90,000 people employed by over 130 local transport operators have failed to make progress.

The exact demands and the length of Friday's walkouts varied from place to place.

In Berlin, workers with the local transport authority walked off the job until 10 a.m.; in Hamburg, Cologne, Hannover and elsewhere, the strike was to last all day. Bavaria, where there are no negotiations at present, was the only region not affected.

The dispute centers on demands for better working conditions, such as a shorter working week and extra compensation days for shift and night work. Coinciding contract negotiations in the rail, airport and local transport sectors have made for a frustrating few weeks for German travers and commuters.

The German railway system is involved in a separate dispute that centers on a train drivers' union's demand for a shorter working week. In an unrelated dispute that centers on pay demands, Ver.di on Thursday called security workers at most of Germany's major airports out on a one-day strike that prompted widespread flight cancellations.

Pokhara Balloon gets permission to fly up to 9,000 feet



PHOTO: TRN

Balloon in air as seen in the picture.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Balloon Nepal, the only company in Nepal offering hot air balloon flights from Pokhara, has recently been authorised to ascend to 9,000 feet above ground level.

Bikram Bade, President of Balloon Nepal, stated that previously restricted to a maximum altitude of 3,000 feet, the balloons can now offer passengers an enhanced view of the Annapurna snow range, Pokhara, and breathtaking views of the sunrise and sunset.

Balloon Nepal was granted permission to fly from Lauruk to Chankpur area of Pokhara after frequently monitoring the tower frequency of Pokhara Regional International Airport by the ministerial decision of the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, said Mukesh Dangol, an ATC officer with the ministry.

According to Bade, the approval was secured following a thorough technical examination of the flight site and a detailed study of the flight manual provided by the manufacturer of the balloon currently in use.

Hot air ballooning, offering an exhilarating blend of adventure and tranquillity, has become a unique attraction in Pokhara, Nepal, for enthusiasts of adventure tourism.

The hot air balloon comprises an 'envelope,' resembling a balloon, which is filled with air using internal fans. Once the balloon takes shape, gas combustion heats the air, elevating the balloon. The pilot controls the airspeed, and a 32-square-meter basket, suspended beneath the 21-meter-high balloon, accommodates up to eight passengers simultaneously.

While drifting in the hot air balloon, passengers are treated to breathtaking views of Pokhara city, various lakes, Pumdikot, Sarangkot, and the expansive mountain range. The time of the flight allows observers to witness the stunning transitions of sunrise and sunset.

Nepali tourists can experience a half-hour hot air balloon flight for Rs 9,500 per person, with a reduced fee of Rs 5,000 for children aged between 3 to 9 years. Distinct fees apply to citizens of India, SAARC countries, and other nations.



PHOTO COURTESY: EMBASSY OF INDIA, KATHMANDU
A delegation of Nepali lawmakers led by Chairman of International Relations and Tourism Raj Kishor Yadav meets with External Affairs Minister of India Dr. S Jaishankar in New Delhi, India on Friday.

Fake currencies seized in Harion

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, Feb. 2

Police have seized fake currencies of Rs. 172,000 from Harion of Sarlahi. The police have also arrested two persons involved in the smuggling of the counterfeit currency.

According to Police Inspector Anil Raj Giri of the Area Police Office, they seized 21 bundles of papers which were cut and designed in the size of a currency note of 1,000 denomination.

The fake currencies were smuggled packing them inside a Tasty Biscuit's wrapping papers. The smugglers have placed the fake currency on the top and bottom of the packets of biscuits, said police. Police have also seized 20 packets of the biscuits.

Police have arrested 36-year-old Sanjaya Sahani of Madhavnarayan Municipality-2 of Rautahat and Amarendra Mahara, 23, of Balara Municipality-7 of Sarlahi district in connection to the case.

After the police received the information about the smuggling, a police team led by Inspector Giri was mobilised in the area.

The operation became successful after the police intervened on their motorcycles with registration numbers Province 2-027 Pa 4256 and BR 30 AC 8318 when they arrived at Kadariya of Harion Municipality-11 along the East-West Highway. According to the police, they were coming to Lalbandi from Karmaiya.

When police raided their bags, the fake currency notes and some amount of hashish were recovered, police said.

Mid-hill Highway blocked by snowfall in Rukum



PHOTO: RAJU LAMICHHANE/TRN
The Mid-Hill Highway at the Rindaha area of Musikot Municipality-7 and 8 in Rukum West, as well as in Paathilalna, situated in the border area between Rukum East and Baglung districts blocked by snowfall, Friday.

BY RAJU LAMICHHANE
Rukum West, Feb. 2

The Mid-Hill Highway has been obstructed since Thursday morning because of heavy snowfall and rainfall.

It has been reported that traffic disruptions are occurring due to snowfall at the Rindaha area of Musikot Municipality 7 and 8 in Rukum West, as well as in Paathilalna, situated in the border area between Rukum East and Baglung districts

After the highway was blocked, vehicles that head to Kathmandu from Rukum West headquarters via Rukum East were not allowed to ply while the vehicles heading to Kathmandu from other routes and the areas of the district were rerouted.

The buses departing for Kathmandu from the western region of the district are being redirected to pass through Sallibazaar in Salyan, Kohalpur in Banke and Butwal, Rupandehi. According to Debit Gautam, an employee of Rukum Sisne Transport Private Limited, no buses have been dispatched from Rukum West via Mid-Hill Highway to Rukum East, Baglung, Pokhara, and Kathmandu.

Buses have been dispatched via Salyan, Dang, and Butwal. Gautam mentioned that it would be challenging for the vehicles to pass through the Mid-Hill Highway until the snow is cleared or gets melted.

Currently, Rukum Sisne Transport Private Limited, Saniveri Transport Services, Battalion Transport, Kamaldaha Transport, and Ghodaghodi Transport are providing bus services to Kathmandu from Rukum West.

MUNICIPALITY GETS DISABLED-FRIENDLY OFFICE BUILDING

BY CHITRA MIJAR
Sindhupalchowk, Feb. 2

A beautiful administrative building has been constructed for Panchpokhari Thangpal Rural Municipality despite its inconvenient location in Sindhupalchowk. The constructed building is environment-friendly, disability-friendly, technology-friendly and earthquake-resistant.

Tasi Lama, the Chairman of the Rural Municipality, informed that the construction of the building was completed in five years for Rs. 119 million.

Lama said that the building was constructed with a grant of Rs. 38.4 million from the federal government, Rs. 23.7 million support from the District Coordination Committee and Rs. 48.7 million from Panchpokhari Thangpal Rural Municipality.

The construction work of the administrative building in Ward No. 6 commenced on May 25, 2020. There are a total of 35 rooms spread across six buildings. These buildings include the executive building, administrative building, Panchpokhari meeting hall with a capacity to accommodate over 500 people, Panchpokhari museum, Panchpokhari library, emergency room, agricultural information centre, breastfeeding room, Panchpokhari guesthouse, public toilets and other structures.

According to Laxman Kuikel, the Chief Administrative Officer of the rural municipality, a multi-purpose building has been constructed on a land area of 45 ropanis and 15 anas. He said that 63 locals donated land for the construction of the building. On January 31, 2024, CPN-UML chairman KP Sharma Oli inaugurated the building.

In the district, which comprises three municipalities and nine rural municipalities, most of the local-level administrative buildings have been constructed. However, in Sunkoshi Rural Municipality, where the finalisation of its permanent centre remains unresolved, the issue of constructing office building has become a distant prospect.

Syangja Hospital introduces physiotherapy services



PHOTO: TRN
The patients at the hospital premise to physiotherapy services at the Syangja District Hospital, Friday.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Syangja, Feb. 2

Physiotherapy services have recently begun at the Syangja District Hospital, ending the compulsion for patients to travel to Pokhara or Kathmandu to receive treatments.

This development, supported by the Gandaki Province government, is a result of improved infrastructure and the acquisition of necessary equipment.

Indra Bahadur Godar, the chairman of the Hospital Management Committee, emphasised the effectiveness of physiotherapy for conditions like arthritis, intoxication and paralysis. This service aims to address a range of issues, including torn muscles, respiratory problems and neck/back pain.

Dr. Rukbina Adhikari, Hospital Head and Medical Superintendent, highlighted that the hospital would utilise both machines and manual techniques, with the duration ranging from half an hour to two hours depending on the nature of the disease while providing treatment.

The introduction of physiotherapy at the District Hospital in Putlibazaar Municipality-3 is a positive step, and it has been well-received by the community.

The hospital, initially approved for 15 beds, has expanded its services by adding 10 more beds under the Hospital Management Committee.

The hospital, situated in the western part of Pokhara, has made significant strides in healthcare services. In addition to physiotherapy, it offers a comprehensive range of facilities, including MGDP, outpatient, surgery, kidney dialysis, maternal and child services, eye and dental care, video x-rays, health insurance, disability support room, and 24-hour emergency facilities.

The recent enhancements have led to a substantial increase in patient visits, with more than 150 individuals seeking medical attention, a notable improvement from previous years when patient numbers were minimal.

Kawasoti hosting bird festival on February 9,10

BY BOM LAL GIRI
Nawalpur, Feb. 2

Kawasoti, the headquarters of Nawalpur district, is all set to host a bird festival on February 9 and 10.

Ornithologists, environmentalists, eco-tourism experts, and participants from various organisations are expected to grace the festival.

Man Shant Ghimire, the president of the Pokhara Bird Society. said, "The festival will feature activities such as bird watching, bird identification training, trail packages, a photo exhibition, a bird art competition, vulture activity observation, jungle safaris and presentations showcasing the cultures of Tharu, Musahar and Bote communities."

The festival is being held to develop Kawasoti as a bird tourism destination and highlight the importance of bird protection, said Ghimire. He further informed that the festival is being organised in collaboration with Jatayu Restaurant Management Committee and with the assistance of the Bird Education Society.

Ornithologist and founder of Jatayu Restaurant, DB Chaudhary said, "The programme also includes discussions on the impact of climate change on bird migration, a bird symposium, panel discussions, and other events."

Currently, 551 species of birds have been documented in the Narayani riverside area, he added.



PHOTO: BOM LAL GIRI/TRN
Organisers holding discussion to host a bird festival on February 9 and 10 in Kawasoti, the headquarters of Nawalpur district, Friday.

Chairman of the Bird Education Society, Tikaram Giri, said that Rs. 1.9 million is allocated for the Bird Festival.

He also mentioned that the festival is funded by organisations such as WWF, Himalayan Tail, Nature Nepal and Lee Bird. Gandaki Province Government and Kawasoti Municipality too have supported the programme.

Chaudhary said, "Bird tourism in Nepal has attracted tourists worldwide, and due to its higher expense compared to other forms of tourism, bird tourism has the potential to bring in foreign currency."

"Bird tourism has evolved into a high-cost endeavour. Tourists are required to pay up to US$100 per day for a guide, and at times they wait for three to four days, or even as long as 10 to 15 days, to catch sight of specific birds," Chowdhury explained. This is why well-off visitors opt for this type of tourism. On the other hand, it significantly contributes to foreign currency inflow.

Buddha statue installed by curtailing wedding expenses

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Hetauda, Feb. 2

Pratap Bista, a journalist from Makawanpur district, has funded the installation of a Buddha statue with the funds allocated for his son's wedding ceremony. At a time when extravagant weddings are taken as a status symbol, journalist Bista chose to use the funds to install a Buddha statue at Trivenidham, situated in Hetauda Sub-Metropolitan City-9.

The Buddha statue unveiling ceremony took place on Thursday and as per reports Rs.1.2 million was invested in building the statue.

Mayor Meena Kumari Lama and Deputy Mayor Rajesh Baniya of Hetauda Sub- Metropolitian City jointly unveiled the statue.

Bista, who is also a former president of the Federation of Nepalese Journalists, Bagmati Province, said, "As a popular proverb goes, you must be the change you wish to see in the world, I tried to set the example that funds allocated for extravagant weddings can be used for a social cause" Bista had previously supported the construction of a building for the Manav Sewa Ashram situated in Hetauda-9 with an expenditure of Rs. 500,000, during his elder son's wedding.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Transmission Directorate
Grid Development Department
Nepalgunj-Nanpara 132 kV Transmission Line Project
Phone No.: +977 01-4153174, Email: nntlp132@gmail.com
Date of Publication : 2080/10/20 (February 03, 2024)

Notice of Intent to Award

IFB No.: NNTL-NCB-2080/81-01, "Design, Supply, Construction, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Nepalgunj-Nanpara 132 kV Transmission Line with Associated 132 kV Bay Expansion Work"

This is to notify that, it is our intention to award the contract for Design, Supply, Construction, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Nepalgunj-Nanpara 132 kV Transmission Line with Associated 132 kV Bay Expansion Work, IFB No. NNTL-NCB-2080/81-01 to M/s. Mudbhary & Joshi Construction Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu as their bid price NRs. 462,392,868.34 (In Word: Four Hundred Sixty Two Million Three Hundred Ninety Two Thousand Eight Hundred Sixty Eight Rupees and Paisa Thirty Four only) excluding Tax & VAT as corrected and modified in accordance with the Instructions to Bidders is hereby selected as substantially responsive lowest evaluated bid.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

It always seems impossible until it's done.
-- Nelson Mandela

Culture Serves As Soft Side Of Politics

Dev Raj Dahal



Democratic politics promotes the cultured life of people offering them collective memory and opportunity for choice based on norms, beliefs, tradition and institutions vital to spur social mobility and progress. It bridges the attainment gaps, not splitting the sources of livelihood and knowledge into the public and the private and confining it to mere biological survival. It is vital to reduce the emotional distance of Nepalis living in various stages of human progress and diverse geographical spots. Culture as a soft side of politics provides a template for thinking, feeling and acting. Managing this soft side is, thus, vital for the evolution of civilisation that blends a variety of cultures. The normative milieu of cultures stores memory and sets a hope to create a modern nation where all Nepalis make full use of their potential and talent for self-transformation and attain public goods.

Utilitarian penchant

This means civic maturity of Nepalis, their acculturation and character building are vital to lift them to full stature and build community for stable social life. So far politics of Nepal can be labeled into various types, not each of them is culturally sensitive to reconcile reason and faith, rights and duties and state and people. The utilitarian version of power politics drafts policies and makes decisions that guarantee the highest scale of people's satisfaction so that in the future they stick to those leaders and parties and vote for their hit in elections. Its side of democracy is rooted in shaping the interest of government compatible with the general will, considering that they are the best judges of their own welfare.

In Nepal, however, utilitarian politics is deemed as calculating, bargaining, maneuvering and opportunistic devoid of ideological and ethical drapes where leaders adopt any policy or strategy which suits their mostly personal, not party, public or national interests. The usual obedience of the people to the rule of law is a virtuous act but uncritical sticking to party bosses may lead to a political culture of clannish conformism, authoritarianism, cultic traits and poverty of inner vigilance. The culture of ditching each other is popping up in the nation. Political elites of most hues versed in certain universalistic values of democracy often parade its basic ideals both to infantilise democracy and subordinate native culture, religion, languages and practices considering them parochial.

They seek to replace them with modernity in the image of advanced nations and uphold the burden of defending it. This process amounts to substituting feudalism by external dependence and harboring a feeling of cultural cringe, not appropriating and appreciating the sanity of syncretic culture of Nepal emerged from cross-cultural fertilization. Cultural amnesia, except in the promotion of tourism, evokes the ire of faith-based leaders, parties and intellectuals with strategic rationality in the same way as those de-culturalized leaders' geopolitical flirtation bent on dividing population for electoral constituencies, not nation building.

Many nations are now self-defining, pursuing modernisation, decolonisation and discovering common cause with each social stratum to enrich inner life and forge national unity. Nepal has once articulated a policy of Nepalisation through the normative texture and hues of languages, cultures, religions, arts, music, poems, stories and philosophy without becoming insular and inferior. They helped the leaders to build their national identity without deflating social and cultural mosaic. It had only aimed to transform all mini identities of Nepalis into the meta identity of citizens with equal rights. The current establishment has, however, promulgated Nepali constitution, along materialist and postmodernist prejudice, sought to differentiate Nepalis on the basis of mini identities and stratified population for instrumental purpose without any reflection for balance, reciprocity and affinity to national self-determination.

It may expedite the colonial sort of elite politics of utilizing the art of divide and rule and command and control thus flagging the concept of the sovereignty of collective Nepali demos bound by bonding and bridging capital of tradition, institution, constitution and deliberation. Liberation of the ordinary folk from the particular elite class dominating and monopolising power and wealth is crucial for democratic nation-building based on community spirit, entrepreneurial zeal and wise citizenship filled with the soft power of its culture. Organic intellectuals now need the mobilisation of centripetal forces of society to tide over the crises occurring in various fields and shore up its enlightened tradition and deeply embedded culture of tolerance of social and cultural pluralism. This can free up the empirical bias of leaders stoking sectarian unrest with its emancipatory ideals, create a just society and formulate the wisdom of eco-sensitive progress.

Popular sovereignty espoused by Nepali constitution admits the centrality of people in the statecraft where power flows from the people, not top-down or outside. Frail leadership harnesses little public purpose based on public opinion and civic culture built on the connection of law to morality. Nepali society remains segmented into various sub-cultures and herds, each has its own cultural rationality and richness which has contributed to the formation of the state and national identity. The proponents of a primordial source of knowledge believe that liberation of leaders from history, culture and tradition marks conscious alienation from the national spiritual, ecological and moral context, intellectual heritage and condition of people and their eternal notion of dharma. Certain intellectuals rooted in a group-think mentality are unmindful of the modern version of individual and human rights espoused by the nation.

Native scholars believe that the positivist and ethno-centric version of social science, its policy making style and political culture is inapt to capture the spirit of Nepali society which is too pluralistic laden with its own positive tradition of caring and sharing as opposed to borrowed version of negation, indoctrination and contradictions. The contextual account of culture is vital to indigenize democracy and progress in Nepal. In primordial orientation, people generally perceive that culturally relativist politics gives them preference to protect their worldview, values, culture, experience and indigenous knowledge. The resurgence of Nepali culture is giving vent to populism in many parties as they find the establishment less attuned to popular expectation generated by democratic politics and cultural definition of politics harbored by Nepal's neighbours for their post-Western future.

> Creative cultural production is essential to refresh the public sentiment and overcome the power bloc model representing a loss of its meaning by correcting its course through a fusion of national and world cultures as a soft side of politics.

Self-interest is the motive force of rationalism. It is bound by reason and science, not emotion, feeling, sentiment, culture or religion, the soft side of politics, before making policies and decisions. Yet the emotional appeal and campaign of Nepali political parties and leaders influence voters' behaviour and impel partisan attachment. It is a model of politics in which people favour the parties or leaders of their choice, vote for them and keep affinity with them in terms of reason and action. The founding spirit of Nepal's mainstream parties such as Nepali Congress, CPN-UML and CPN- Maoist Centre were scientific ideologies but now they have evolved overlapping interest for power and diverse partnership to race to the top. Aroused by the fear of one another's ambition, the rationalist model of politics couched in Westernisation is now facing setbacks for their long years in power with blank promises, overtaking democratic impulse and pushing the nation and people's race to the bottom.

Now Nepalis demand the globalisation of the local rather than the other way round and stress on self-rule, not centralised and personalised ones unable to adapt to popular sovereignty and the zeitgeist. People are inquiring about the tune-up of the establishment in creating a huge size of agencies at multi-scale rule by burdening the future generation with mountains of debts for its privileges in politics and administration. The more the Nepali political parties convert into interest-oriented rational choice, the less remains their ability to articulate the needs of unorganised groups of society. The rational concept of politics harbored by it for long has not been able to purge palpably conscious passion of undue partisan prejudices of leaders to aid meritocratic order amenable to public good and cultural pride.

It can also be considered a club model aiming to create the elite status quo unreflective and economic-deterministic in appetite. The recurrently used term in Nepal is also a syndicate regime where leaders make a bloc of several parties regardless of their differing ideologies or identities to win elections and form a coalition government lending continuity to the cycle of patronage politics. Power-constitutive interest is an incentive and motivation which has ossified the values of democracy in public life, public policy and political culture. Monopolisation of power is the leitmotif and, therefore, it has the temptation to cultivate partiocracy, not democracy based on a model of choice Nepali voters' desire. Because of this practice voters previously socialized in the historical identity of parties are indulged in self-interested de-alignment from party politics as utility maximizers, not governed by party's norms and discipline.

Others are swayed by populist lure. They inflame the craze of unthinking crowds, breeding political instability and elevation of the norms and values of good citizenship. The power-bloc politics discounts the future, a culture of intergenerational justice and allows the status quo to persist, closes options for democratic dissent and tolerates impunity and violence and thus faces tension spilling into popular plea for inter and intra-party democracy. It expects the optimal negotiation of rival interests in the golden mean.

Dilemma

Top Nepali leaders are now in a dilemma: easing generational transfer of leadership might freeze them devoid of warmth of power while sticking to power life-long in a post-ideological order without sound performance and inability to resolve piling of national issues might cost the party's future. The spasm of populist and conservative parties have adopted this model for a short time but soon departed as they found that the ends are incompatible with the means. Rastriya Swotantra Party's anti-corruption tirade is an example. Even the Rastriya Prajatantra Party and Janamat Party found trouble in adjusting with the establishment and left their previous electoral alliances and power-sharing. The former believes in a politics of cultural and spiritual de-colonisation to maintain the memory of tradition and institutions while the latter favours justice for the oppressed.

Those outside the establishment articulate collective concern for increasing depopulation of the nation by easing massive migration of youths abroad for its inability to provide a favourable condition where they can live a collective life. They do not have control over their fate and livelihood means. This provides a space for new forces to compete with the establishment for scarce political resources. Migration of youth abroad deprives the integrative and idealistic dimension of Nepali society and critical mass of production and change. Creative cultural production is essential to refresh the public sentiment and overcome the power bloc model representing a loss of its meaning by correcting its course through a fusion of national and world cultures as a soft side of politics.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

The Art Of Parenting

ILENE STRAUSS COHEN

Picture this: Anna, a mother of two, finds herself constantly torn between conflicting advice from parenting books, online "parenting gurus," and well-meaning friends and family. She wonders, "What's the best way to raise my children? How can I ensure they grow into healthy, happy, and successful individuals?" Are you, like Anna, trying to navigate the complex web of parenting advice? If so, this is for you.

With countless parenting "experts" out there, it's easy to get overwhelmed. But what does research say about how we should parent? What does it mean to be a good parent, and how can your children benefit from your parenting style? Let's delve into these questions. According to several studies, the most effective parenting style is often authoritative. This involves a balance of setting clear expectations and rules while also demonstrating affection and responsiveness. It encourages open communication and values the child's point of view.

A child-cantered approach characterises the authoritative parenting style. This means that while clear rules and guidelines are set, parents are also empathetic to their children's feelings and encourage their independence. This style differs significantly from authoritarian parenting, where high demands and low responsiveness often lead to children feeling pressured and judged. On the other extreme lies permissive parenting, which, although high in responsiveness, lacks rules and discipline, potentially leading to children lacking self-regulation and becoming self-centred.

Authoritative parents strike a balance between these two extremes. They maintain high expectations and establish clear rules, but they also express warmth and responsiveness, fostering an environment of respect and open dialogue. This approach helps children feel secure, capable, and powerful in managing their feelings and behaviours, promoting their happiness and success. Numerous studies have demonstrated the benefits of authoritative parenting. These benefits include higher academic achievement, greater self-esteem, better social skills, and lower levels of depression and anxiety. They are also more likely to develop good social skills and behave responsibly.

While authoritative parenting yields positive outcomes, it's important to remember that every child is unique. What works for one might not work for another. As such, it's crucial to critically evaluate parenting advice and adjust based on your child's needs. For instance, a child with attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD) might require more structure and consistency than what the typical authoritative style provides. Parents might need to implement more explicit rules and routines in such cases. Moreover, too much negotiation or dialogue might overwhelm an exceptionally introverted child. For such children, clear and concise communication might be more beneficial. Additionally, a child with autism might struggle with understanding the reasons behind rules or restrictions. In these scenarios, using more visual aids and maintaining a consistent routine can be helpful.

Remember, good parenting isn't about being perfect. It's about being responsive, adaptable, and always willing to learn and grow for the sake of our children. Looking back at our initial example, Anna, a mother practicing authoritative parenting, can take several steps to tailor her approach to her child's unique needs further. If her child exhibits signs of being highly sensitive, she might adopt gentler communication methods, prioritising empathy and understanding over assertiveness. She may also consider creating a calm, predictable environment to help her child feel safe and secure.

On the other hand, if her child is showing signs of ADHD, Anna may need to establish more structured routines and clearly defined rules. She might also consider integrating visual aids, like charts or diagrams, to help her child understand the consequences of their actions. As with any parent, the key for Anna is to continually evaluate her parenting strategies, making necessary adjustments based on her child's responses and needs.

Indeed, parenting can be a challenging journey, filled with uncertainties and hurdles. However, it's important to remember that every challenge presents an opportunity for growth and learning, both for the child and the parent. As we strive to understand our children better and adapt to their unique needs, we develop resilience, empathy, and deeper bonds of love.

-- Psychology Today

Cervical Cancer: A Serious Public Health Threat

Deepa Ghimire



"One woman dies of cervical cancer every two minutes... Each one is a tragedy, and we can prevent it."-Dr Tedros Ghebreyesus, WHO Director General

Cervical cancer, despite being a preventable and potentially curable disease, is the fourth most common cause of cancer among women worldwide with an estimated 604,000 cases and 342,000 related deaths reported in 2020 where 90 per cent of mortality occurs in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs). Inadequate screening systems, a lack of public awareness and education, and a paucity of medical professionals with the training and experience to diagnose and treat precancerous lesions of the cervix are frequently to blame for the higher incidence and mortality rates of cervical cancer in low- and middle-income countries.

According to Global Cancer Observatory 2020, 200,000 new cases (32 per cent of the global burden) and 100,000 deaths (34 per cent of global mortality) of cervical cancer occurred in the South East Asian Region accounting for a significant share of the global cervical cancer burden and Nepal is no an exception. Cervical cancer ranks as the first most frequent cancer among women in Nepal and the second most frequent cancer among women between 15 and 44 years of age with an incidence of 16.4 per 100,000 women, compared to the WHO-desired target of 4 per 100,000 women, which is almost four times the target to end the public health concern of cervical cancer. Recent estimates indicate that every year 2,244 women are diagnosed with cervical cancer and 1,493 die from the disease.

Prevention and control

According to WHO projections, countries may empower an estimated 250,000 women to contribute to the global economy, which is projected to be worth $28 billion through 2050, by investing in cervical cancer prevention and control. So, in May 2018, for the first time ever in the history the world made a commitment to eliminate cervical cancer that incorporates scaling up interventions to achieve the 90-70-90 goals by 2030: (i) 90 per cent of girls fully vaccinated for human papillomavirus (HPV) by the age of 15; (ii) 70 per cent of women screened by the age of 35 and again by the age of 45; and (iii) 90 per cent of women with pre-cancer treated and 90 per cent of women with invasive cancer managed.

As the WHO marks the third anniversary of a historic global movement in November 2023 of eliminating cervical cancer, member states have demonstrated a remarkable political resolve by formulating and implementing national elimination plans. However, Nepal is still at a sluggish rate. Other SEAR countries – Bhutan, Indonesia, Maldives, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Thailand – had already introduced the HPV vaccination nationwide but Nepal is still in a planning phase. Administration of two doses of HPV vaccine for 9 and 14 years aged girls before the onset of sexual activity as per the WHO recommendation is the best primary prevention against cervical cancer. However, numerous studies have emphasised the high costs, obstacles in the supply chain, and the absence of national HPV vaccination programmes being a hindrance to low coverage i.e. 15 per cent.

> A strong immunisation approach that incorporates cervical cancer screening and HPV vaccination into community-based immunisation programmes and human resource frameworks may be the key to the remarkable success.

Along with the detrimental impact on health and mortality, cervical cancer has a significant social and economic cost in countries like Nepal. The data obtained from various cervical cancer screening camp adds more evidence to the emerging burden of cervical cancer. A cervical health examination of 2,121 women from eight districts of Madhes province showed 59 of the examinees have cervical cancer, and 562 women are at high risk of uterine prolapse. *(Source: Kathmandu Post, July 3, 2023).* Similar screening camp through VIA (Visual Inspection Acetic Acid) test conducted at Baiteshwor and Jiri municipality, Dolakha in December 2023 showed a positive case of 42 and 146 women with second, third and fourth degree uterine prolapse out of 858 women tested. *(Primary Source: Green Tara Nepal)*

Immunisation

These figures are merely the tip of the iceberg; further research is needed to fully understand the spectrum of cervical cancer. Social and cultural constraints such as ethnic variances, public awareness, reaching out to non-schooling girls, consent concerns, and feeble political commitment need to be uprooted to eliminate the cervical cancer. Unless all teenage girls, regardless of their social or economic background, are not enrolled in an efficacious HPV vaccination programme, the issue of cervical cancer will continue to persist. A strong immunisation approach that incorporates cervical cancer screening and HPV vaccination into community-based immunisation programmes and human resource frameworks may be the key to the remarkable success.

(Ghimire is a public health professional)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 3, 1974

Agriculture Exhibition Held

Tribeni, Feb. 2: A four-day-long agriculture exhibition was held here recently on the occasion of the Tribeni fair under the aegis of the Nawalparasi district agriculture development office, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Stop Brain Drain



This is in reference to the news report titled "*Brain drain should be stopped: PM*" published in this daily on Feb. 2. Brain drain has become a serious issue plaguing our country. These days everyone seems to be longing to go abroad both for foreign employment and better life.

Those at the lower economic ranks desire to go to the Gulf to earn some money while those who are educated and are relatively affluent aspire to go to the West in pursuit of better life and in the hope of giving better education and future to their children and settling there permanently. This phenomena has reached epic proportions and if it continues, there will be a day when the country will be left with old, poor, and disabled people.

The most alarming of all is the exodus of promising youths able to contribute immensely to the country as a whole and its people. Their exit bodes ill for the nation, and they must be incentivised to stay here.

Kapil Basyal
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

One night a husband and wife were sleeping and suddenly the wife woke up.

"Honey, wake up! I think there's a burglar downstairs, and it sounds like they're eating the cake I made!" said the wife.

Half asleep, the husband answers, "So should I call the police or the ambulance?"

A woman goes to a psychiatrist and says, "Doctor, you've got to do something about my husband -- he thinks he's a refrigerator!"

"I wouldn't worry too much about it," the doctor replies. 'Lots of people have harmless delusions. It will pass."

"But you don't understand," the woman insists. "He sleeps with his mouth open, and the little light keeps me awake."

India exhibits naval power

AP
Srinagar, India, Feb. 2



PHOTO: AP

Confetti and smoke in the colours of the Indian national flag mark the entry of INS Vindhyagiri, a new warship for the Indian navy, into the Hooghly river in Kolkata, India, Aug. 17, 2023.

For decades, India has focused its defense policy on its land borders with rivals Pakistan and China. Now, as its global ambitions expand, it is beginning to flex its naval power in international waters, including anti-piracy patrols and a widely publicized deployment close to the Red Sea to help protect ships from attacks during Israel's war with Hamas.

India sent three guided missile destroyers and reconnaissance aircraft in November when Yemen-based Houthi rebels began targeting ships in solidarity with Hamas, causing disruptions in a key trading route that handles about 12% of global trade.

The deployment highlights the country as a "proactive contributor" to international maritime stability, said Vice Adm. Anil Kumar Chawla, who retired in 2021 as head of India's southern naval command.

"We are not doing it only out of altruism. Unless you are a maritime power you can never aspire to be a global power," Chawla said. India, already a regional power, is positioning itself "as a global player today, an upcoming global power," he said.

India is widely publicizing the deployments, signalling its desire to assume a wider responsibility in maritime security to the world.

The Indian navy has helped at least four ships, three of which were attacked by Houthi rebels and another that Washington blamed on Iran, a charge denied by Tehran. It has also conducted several anti-piracy missions.

Iran-backed Houthi rebels have targeted dozens of ships in the Red Sea, saying they are seeking a cease-fire in the Gaza Strip.

The U.S. and its allies have responded with multiple rounds of bombings of rebel positions. India has not joined the U.S.-led force battling the Houthis.

On Jan. 26, the Indian guided missile destroyer INS Visakhapatnam assisted the crew of a Marshall Islands-flagged tanker in fighting a fire after it was hit by a missile in the Gulf of Aden. About 10 days earlier, the Visakhapatnam responded to a distress call by the U.S.-owned Genco Picardy merchant vessel following a drone attack in the same waters.

"Maritime security has not been a strong pillar of India's foreign policy engagements in a way we are beginning to see now," said Darshana M. Baruah, a fellow at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. "China is a factor in this."

The rivals are already locked in a military standoff along their disputed border high in the mountains.

The navy has also built strategic partnerships through participation in joint exercises with other nations in the region and beyond.

Baruah, who directs the Indian Ocean Initiative at the Carnegie Endowment, said there is a "need for Delhi's strategic thinking to be maritime-oriented, not just as an option for crisis response but as a theater to advance India's most pressing geopolitical and strategic priorities in the Indo-Pacific."

India, the U.S., Australia and Japan are members of the Indo-Pacific strategic alliance known as the Quad, which has repeatedly accused China of flexing its military muscles in the South China Sea and aggressively pushing its maritime territorial claims. The navies of the four countries regularly hold drills seen as part of an initiative to counter China's growing assertiveness in the Pacific.

Beijing maintains that its military is purely defensive to protect what it says are its sovereign rights, and calls the Quad an attempt to contain its economic growth and influence.

'Britain could recognize a Palestinian state'

AP
Riyak, Lebanon, Feb. 2



PHOTO: AP

Britain's Foreign Secretary David Cameron, left, speaks with Lebanese caretaker Prime Minister Najib Mikati in Beirut, Lebanon, Thursday, Feb. 1, 2024.

Britain's top diplomat said Thursday that his country could officially recognize a Palestinian state after a cease-fire in Gaza without waiting for the outcome of what could be yearslong talks between Israel and the Palestinians on a two-state solution.

Foreign Secretary David Cameron, speaking to The Associated Press during a visit Thursday to Lebanon intended to tamp down regional tensions, said no recognition could come while Hamas remained in Gaza, but that it could take place while Israeli negotiations with Palestinian leaders were continuing.

U.K. recognition of an independent state of Palestine, including in the United Nations, "can't come at the start of the process, but it doesn't have to be the very end of the process," said Cameron, a former British prime minister.

"It could be something that we consider as this process, as this advance to a solution, becomes more real," Cameron said. "What we need to do is give the Palestinian people a horizon towards a better future, the future of having a state of their own."

That prospect is "absolutely vital for the long-term peace and security of the region," he said.

Britain, the U.S. and other Western countries have supported the idea of an independent Palestine existing alongside Israel as a solution to the region's most intractable conflict, but have said Palestinian independence should come as part of a negotiated settlement. There have been no substantive negotiations since 2009.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, for his part, has publicly rejected the creation of an independent Palestinian state after the war, and has even boasted in recent weeks that he was instrumental in preventing Palestinian statehood.

A move by some of Israel's key allies to recognize a Palestinian state without Israel's buy-in could isolate Israel and put pressure on it to come to the table.

Cameron said the first step must be a "pause in the fighting" in Gaza that would eventually turn into "a permanent, sustainable cease-fire."

He added that in order for his country to recognize a Palestinian state, the leaders of the Hamas militant group would need to leave Gaza "because you can't have a two state solution with Gaza still controlled by the people responsible for Oct. 7," referring to the deadly Hamas attack on Israel that triggered the war in Gaza.

Hamas has so far taken the position that its leaders would not leave the enclave as part of a cease-fire deal.

Cameron said his country is also proposing a plan to deescalate tensions on the Lebanon-Israel border, where the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah and Israeli forces have been trading fire near-daily for the past four months, sparking fears of a wider war.

NKorea tests more missiles as Kim calls for war readiness

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Feb. 2

North Korea on Friday extended a provocative series of weapons tests by firing cruise missiles into the sea, as leader Kim Jong Un called for his military to step up war preparations and toured a shipyard.

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said the U.S. and South Korean militaries were analysing the North Korean launches into its western sea. It said South Korea's military detected multiple missiles but it did not immediately provide a specific number or an assessment of their flights.

The launches, which were North Korea's fourth round of cruise missile tests in 2024, came hours after state media reported that Kim reiterated his focus on strengthening his naval forces as he inspected unspecified naval projects at a shipyard in Nampho on the west coast.

Kim in recent months has emphasized efforts to build a nuclear-armed navy to counter what he portrays as growing external threats posed by the United States, South Korea and Japan, which have stepped up their military cooperation in response to Kim's nuclear weapons and missile program.

North Korea's official Korean Central News Agency did not specify when Kim visited Nampho. It paraphrased Kim as saying that the strengthening of the navy "presents itself as the most important issue in reliably defending the maritime sovereignty of the country and stepping up the war preparations."

KCNA did not specify the types of warships are being built in Nampho, but said they were related to a five-year military development plan set during a ruling party congress in early 2021. During those meetings, Kim revealed an extensive wish list of advanced military assets, which included nuclear-powered submarines and nuclear missiles that can be launched from underwater.

During the inspection, Kim was briefed on the progress of his naval projects and remaining technological challenges and ordered workers to "unconditionally" complete the efforts within the timeframe of the plan that runs through 2025, KCNA said.

Kim Inae, a spokesperson for South Korea's Unification Ministry, said it was the first time the ministry was aware of that state media reported on Kim Jong Un conducting a military inspection in Nampho. That could suggest an expansion of naval projects from the country's eastern shipyard of Sinpo, which has been the North's base for submarine construction.

Gas explosion kills 3 people, injures 270 others in Kenya

AP
Nairobi, Kenya, Feb. 2



PHOTO: AP

An injured man walks at a scene of explosion in Nairobi, Kenya Friday, Feb. 2, 2024.

A vehicle loaded with gas exploded and set off an inferno that burned homes and warehouses in Kenya's capital, killing at least three people and injuring more than 270, officials said Friday, with the death toll expected to rise.

Many residents were likely inside their homes when the fire reached their houses in the Mradi area of the Nairobi neighbourhood of Embakasi, government spokesman Isaac Mwaura said.

The truck explosion ignited a huge fireball, and a flying gas cylinder set off a fire that burned down a garment and textile warehouse called Oriental Godown, Mwaura said. Several other vehicles and businesses were damaged by the inferno that started around 11:30 p.m. Thursday.

At the scene after daybreak, several houses and shops were burned out. The shell of the vehicle believed to have started the explosion was lying on its side. The roof of a four-story residential building about 200 meters (yards) from the scene of the explosion was broken by a flying gas cylinder. Electric wires lay on the ground. Nothing remained in the burned-out warehouse except the shells of several trucks.

Alfred Juma, an aspiring politician, said he heard loud noise from a gas cylinder in a warehouse next to his house. "I started waking up neighbors asking them to leave," Juma said.

He said he warned a black car not to drive through the area, but the driver insisted and his vehicle stalled because of the fumes. "He attempted to start the car three times and that's when there was an explosion and the fire spread into the (warehouse) setting off other explosions."

He said he grabbed two children and they hid in a sewage ditch until the explosions ended. His family hadn't been present, but Juma lost everything he owned in the fire.

"Police were turning away everyone and so it was difficult to access my house and I had to seek a place to sleep until this morning," neighbor Caroline Karanja said. She said the smell and smoke were still choking, and she would have to stay away for a while because she had young children.

PRISM

Opossum caught on camera stealing cookies

Texas: A security camera at a Texas home captured the moment a box of cookies delivered to the front door was stolen by an unlikely porch pirate -- an opossum.

The Southlake Department of Public Safety said a local resident identified only as Dr. M shared his security camera footage after the theft.

Dr. M's son, who was celebrating his 15th birthday, had been given some Tiff's Treats cookies by a family friend, and the delivery was left on the family's front step.

The son later discovered the balloon left by the delivery worker, as well as a bag of icing, but the box of cookies was found empty in the family's side yard.

Alaska bears found wandering in Florida

Florida: A sheriff's deputy in Florida responded to a call from a member of the public about some bears in the road and arrived to find a pair of young Kodiak bears -- a species found only in Alaska.

The Okaloosa County Sheriff's Office said in a Facebook post that the caller told dispatchers the bears he spotted at the side of Old River Road in the Baker area did not appear to be Florida's usual black bears.

"Turns out he was right. These cubs were technically about 3,614 miles from what would normally be 'home' -- in Alaska," the post said.

(AP)

'Israel has gone too far in war in Gaza'

AP
Washington, Feb. 2

Half of U.S. adults say Israel's 15-week-old military campaign in Gaza has "gone too far," a finding driven mainly by growing disapproval among Republicans and political independents, according to a new poll from The Associated Press-NORC Centre for Public Affairs Research.

Broadly, the poll shows support for Israel and the Biden administration's handling of the situation ebbing slightly further across the board. The poll shows 31% of U.S. adults approve of Biden's handling of the conflict, including just 46% of Democrats. That's as an earlier spike in support for Israel following the Hamas attacks Oct. 7 sags.

Melissa Morales, a 36-year-old political independent in Runnemede, New Jersey, says she finds herself watching videos and news from Gaza daily. Images of Palestinian children wounded, orphaned or unhoused by the fighting in Gaza make her mind go to her own 3-year-old boy.

"I just can't even imagine, like, my son roaming the streets, wanting to be safe. Wanting his mom. Or just wanting someone to get him," she said.

Israel's offensive has gone too far, Morales says, and so has the Biden administration's support for it. Biden has supported Israel militarily and diplomatically since the first hours after the Hamas militant group's Oct. 7 attacks, which Israel says killed 1,200 people.

The U.S. has become increasingly isolated in its support of Israel as the Palestinian death toll rises past 27,000, with two-thirds of the victims women and children. The Biden administration says it is pressing Israel to reduce its killing of civilians and allow in more humanitarian aid.

"These kids ... they're needing the end of this," Morales said. "It's such an unfair fight."

John Milor, a cybersecurity expert in Clovis, California, who describes himself as a Republican-voting independent, says he remains "100%" behind Israel.



PHOTO: AP

Pro-Palestinian protesters block the intersection of E St NW at New Jersey Ave. NW, near the Capitol, Thursday, Feb. 1, 2024, in Washington.

But Milor notices more young people in his circle speaking out against Israel. A visit to a family friend led to Milor being aghast when the man's stepson denounced Israelis as "warmongers."

"And I'm like, "You're kidding, right?"' Milor recounted.

''It's not like they asked to be attacked, you know," Milor said by phone this week. "And they still have hostages over there."

The poll shows 33% of Republicans now say Israel's military response has gone too far, up from 18% in November. Fifty-two percent of independents say that, up from 39%. Sixty-two percent of Democrats say they feel that way, roughly the same majority as in November.

In all, 50% of U.S. adults now believe Israel's military offensive has gone beyond what it should have, the poll found. That's up from 40% in an AP-NORC poll conducted in November.

The new poll was conducted from Jan. 25 to 28. That overlapped with the killing of three U.S. troops in Jordan, the first deaths among American service members in what's been widening regional conflict since Oct. 7. U.S. officials blamed a drone strike by a Hamas-allied militia.

The new poll's findings include more worrying news for President Joe Biden when it comes to support from his own political party. Fracture lines are growing in his Democratic base, with some key Democratic blocs that Biden will likely need if he's going to win a second term unhappy with his handling of the conflict.

About 6 in 10 non-white Democrats disapprove of how Biden is approaching the conflict, while about half of white Democrats approve.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1112 – Ramon Berenguer III, Count of Barcelona, and Douce I, Countess of Provence, marry, uniting the fortunes of those two states.
1451 – Sultan Mehmed II inherits the throne of the Ottoman Empire.
1661 – Maratha forces under Chattrapati Shivaji Maharaj defeat the Mughals in the Battle of Umberkhind.
1690 – The colony of Massachusetts issues the first paper money in the Americas.
1787 – Militia led by General Benjamin Lincoln crush the remnants of Shays' Rebellion in Petersham, Massachusetts.
1807 – A British military force, under Brigadier-General Sir Samuel Auchmuty captures the Spanish Empire city of Montevideo, now the capital of Uruguay.
1809 – The Territory of Illinois is created by the 10th United States Congress.
1870 – The Fifteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution is ratified, guaranteeing voting rights to male citizens regardless of race.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba and other leaders attending NC parliamentary party meeting at the Parliament Building, New Baneshwar, Kathmandu on Friday.

Speaker discusses upcoming bill session with chief whips

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Speaker Devraj Ghimire and chief whips and whips of political parties on Friday discussed the upcoming winter session of the parliament commencing on February 5.

In the meeting held at the Singha Durbar-based Parliament Secretariat, they discussed how the winter session, which is witnessing slew of bills, could be made systematic and effective.

CPN (UML) whip Mahesh Bartaula said during the meeting that they drew Speaker's attention towards the need of drafting overdue bills and addressing citizens' concerns systematically in the upcoming session.

Present at the meeting were Deputy Speaker Indira Rana, Minister for Law, Justice, and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung, Nepali Congress Chief Whip Ramesh Lekhal, UML Chief Whip Padam Giri, and CPN (Maoist Centre) Chief Whip Hitraj Pandey.

Afghan women seek active role at Doha conference



ANI/RSS
Kabul, Feb. 2

The prominent members of women's protest movements have urged the United Nations to advocate for the active participation of women in the Doha Conference, scheduled to be held in Afghanistan, as reported by Khaama Press.

In a letter sent to the UN, the Afghan women highlighted that any decision regarding Afghanistan's fate without consulting women would not be acceptable. The open letter carries the signatures of approximately 10 protest movements and was released on Wednesday, following a virtual meeting among women's rights activists.

Notably, the Doha Conference, initiated by the United Nations, is scheduled to be held on February 18 and 19, according to Khaama Press.This is the second Doha Conference focused on Afghanistan, with the first one hosted by the United Nations approximately eight months ago.

Reportedly, during the initial Doha Conference, Afghan women were not represented. Moreover, the letter sent to the UN states that the meaningful presence of women is crucial, given the ongoing violations of women's rights in Afghanistan, including arbitrary detentions of girls, gender-based violence, and acts of gender apartheid, Khaama Press reported.

Officials from the Taliban government have also been invited to attend this conference.However, as women remain deprived of basic human rights in Afghanistan, the women's rights activists argued that women protesters have been fighting against the Taliban's harsh actions against women for the past two and a half years and should be included in the conference.

One of the women's rights activists, Mina Rafiq, emphasised that women who are actively opposing the policies of the Taliban should be invited to the Doha conference."In previous conferences, genuine women representatives were absent, and it was ineffective.

KOSHI CM VOLUNTEERS LABOUR TO MAKE HOUSE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Feb. 2

Kedar Karki, Chief Minister of Koshi Province, contributed volunteer labour to build Sagar Rai's house in Daraihaya of Biratnagar-16 on Friday morning.

Jeevan Bikash Samaj of Katahari has provided the construction materials to the Rai family, which was living in a dilapidated hut with their three children.

Rai had asked lawmaker Yogendra Mandal elected from Morang constituency-5, to help them construct their house, and the lawmaker provided construction materials through Jeevan Bikash Samaj

The Chief Minister contributed volunteer labour as a gesture to support the Rai family which was struggling to manage the labour cost.

Rai got a new home on Friday after Chief Minister Karki and federal lawmaker Mandal participated in volunteer labour.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Karki has announced to provide mattresses, cooking utensils, blankets and other essential items to the Rai family. I have provided volunteer labour to make citizens feel that the Chief Minister is with them, said Chief Minister Karki.

Chief Minister Karki assured that the government will bring a program to provide housing facilities to poor families in the coming days.

Hamas studying Gaza truce

AP
Beirut, Feb. 2

Hamas officials said Friday that the group is studying a proposed cease-fire deal that would include prolonged pauses in fighting in Gaza and swaps of Israeli hostages for Palestinian prisoners, but at the same time appeared to rule out some of its key components.

Osama Hamdan, a senior Hamas official in Beirut, said the group remains committed to its initial demands for a permanent cease-fire. Hamdan also said the group seeks the release of thousands of Palestinian prisoners being held for acts related to the conflict with Israel, including those serving life sentences. He mentioned two by name, including Marwan Barghouti, a popular Palestinian uprising leader seen as a unifying figure.

Hamdan's comments on the prisoners were the most detailed demands yet to be raised by the group in public.

The insistence on large-scale prisoner releases and on an end to the fighting in Gaza put the group at odds with the multi-stage proposal that officials from Egypt, Israel, Qatar and the United States put forth this week. The proposal does not include a permanent cease-fire.

"There is no way that this will be acceptable by the resistance," Hamdan told Lebanon's LBC TV on Friday, referring to proposed successive pauses in fighting. Israeli leaders have said they will keep fighting until Hamas is crushed, even while agreeing to long pauses that are accompanied by the release of hostages.

Hamas and other militants captured about 250 hostages during their deadly Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel that triggered the war. They continue to hold dozens of captives, after more than 100 were released during a one-week truce in November, in exchange for 240 Palestinian prisoners.

Since Israel's offensive began, more than 27,000 Palestinians have been killed and 66,000 wounded, according to the Health Ministry in the Hamas-run territory. The conflict has also left vast swaths of the tiny coastal enclave leveled, displaced 85% of its population and pushed a quarter of residents to starvation.

In his remarks, Hamdan also said Hamas wants to free Palestinian prisoners of all factions — not just those affiliated with the militant group. In addition to Barghouti, he named Ahmed Saadat, the head of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine, a small PLO faction. The prisoner release is a "national cause, not only for Hamas," he said. Both Barghouti and Saadat were convicted of involvement in fatal attacks during the second Palestinian uprising against Israel's occupation a generation ago.

Alluding to additional points of dispute, Hamdan also said that Israel is carving out a buffer zone on the Gaza side of the border. Israel has not acknowledged such plans officially, but satellite photos show new demolition along a 1-kilometer-wide (0.6-mile-wide) path along the border between Israel and the enclave.

As the war nears the four-month mark, fighting continued in the southern city of Khan Younis. The Israeli military said Friday that its efforts focused on fighters, weapons and infrastructure in the city, a key target of Israel's ground offensive in recent weeks.

Tens of thousands of residents of Khan Younis and surrounding areas have fled south to the town of Rafah, on the border with Egypt, which the United Nations said on Friday is becoming a "pressure cooker of despair."

"We fear for what comes next," said Jens Laerke, spokesman for the U.N. Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs. "It's like every week we think, you know, it can't get any worse. Well, go figure. It gets worse." Hamdan's remarks reaffirmed statements from other Hamas officials, including the group's top political leader Ismail Haniyeh, who said Tuesday that the group was studying the terms but remained committed to seeking the "full withdrawal" of Israeli forces from Gaza and steps toward a long-term cease-fire.

Another Hamas official said Friday that the group would answer "very soon" and ask for several unspecified changes. He refused to give any details on what they're seeking or how many hostages would be released in return for how many prisoners.

The multi-stage proposal on the table was drafted by officials from the United States, Israel, Qatar and Egypt. Qatar and Egypt have been serving as mediators between Israel and Hamas.

Align policies with...

Prakash Bahadur Deuba, Minister for Water Resources and Water Supplies, Saraswoti Aryal Tiwari (Gandaki), Minister for Water Resources, Energy and Irrigation Tirtha Bahadur Lama (Bagmati) and Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development Dharma Bahadur Chaudhary (Lumbini) were present in the meeting.

They however expressed concerns over the engagement of federal government in minor projects, underlining the need of correction in such approach.

Energy secretary Gopal Prasad Tiwari, Water and Energy Commission's secretary Sarita Duwadi, Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) managing director Kulman Ghising and Churna Bahadur Oli, director general of Department of Water Resources and Irrigation were among those present in the meeting.

National wetland policy...

According to Khatri, various initiatives should focus on empowering local communities to participate in wetland conservation by involving them in management decisions, adopting sustainable practices, and contributing to conservation activities.

These community-based approaches effectively achieve long-term conservation goals while supporting local livelihoods, he added.

Nepal boasts approximately 242 wetlands covering an area of around 743,500 hectares, accounting for nearly 5 per cent of the country's total land area. These wetlands are recognised as some of the most productive ecosystems globally, according to the Nepal Tourism Board.

Wetlands, home to over 100,000 species, provide essential freshwater and support global food production.

More may be arrested in...

SP Adhikari claimed that during the police investigation, it was found that Thapa being chief of the then Factory had transferred the land in the name of the Company on his own decision.

The report given by the Auditor General in the past over the transfer of the land too had shown that the land was found given without maintaining transparency, claimed the CIB.

According to CIB, on August 26, 1986, Ajit Narayan Singh Thapa along with Arun Chaudhary sealed a promotional agreement to open Champion Footwear Company to be managed by Chaudhary himself.

According to the agreement, Arun Chaudhary Group will have 51 per cent shares with them, 25 per cent in the name of Bansbari Shoe Factory and 24 per cent in the name of the general public in that Shoe Factory, which had an issued capital of Rs. 5 million.

However, it has been found that Bansbari Leather Shoe Factory, which has to invest Rs. 1.25 million, has invested more than Rs. 2.6 million.

Chaudhary Group invested only Rs. 800,000, while the values of the shares allocated in the name of the general public were not disclosed in the agreement.

It was found that the Champion Footwear Company was closed after taking 10 ropanis of land of the Factory, according to CIB.

CIB said that Arun Chaudhary bought the government shares in his company, "The whole plan seems to be only to take the land of Bansbari Shoe Factory rather than investing and promoting the factory."

Rato Machhindranath reconstruction...

The deadline for the project ended in June last year, but the DoA has not extended the term nor has it allocated the budget to complete the remaining works, he said. On June 29, 2020, an agreement was signed with the DoA to hand over the project to Rato Machhindranath Temple Reconstruction Consumer's Committee (RMTRCC) after Prera, Thegim and Tulsi Joint Venture company, which was rebuilding the temple with financial assistance from the Sri Lankan government, abandoned the reconstruction work.

The RMTRCC had begun the reconstruction work of the temple after holding a special worship on July 4, 2020.

The RMTRCC had agreed to complete the reconstruction work at the cost of Rs. 30.8 million.

Shakya said that the committee had dispatched a letter to the DoA asking for the extension of the term and allocation of the budget 15 days before the deadline was to expire. However, the DoA has not yet responded to the letter.

To reconstruct the temple, the DoA has allocated Rs. 24.3 million to the committee so far. The committee had submitted the bills of expenses amounting to Rs. 3.3 million and other expenses of Rs. 1.9 million at the DoA at the end of the project's deadline, which was also not cleared by the DoA, he said. Rs. 1.9 million was spent to pull down the parts of the one-story structure built earlier and refix it.

"We have completed the construction of the ground floor after rectifying the mistakes made by the earlier contractor," said Shakya, adding, "The contractor had installed the door without repairing the damaged part and without adding the missing parts of the door. It took us a lot of time to correct them."

Recently, Lalitpur Metropolitan City (LMC) announced that it would complete the remaining reconstruction works.

The winter session meeting of the metropolis recently decided to allocate a budget of Rs. 10 million to rebuild the temple, said Raju Maharjan, spokesperson for the LMC.

Stating that the temple of archaeological importance, which is a cultural heritage, should not be left in an abandoned situation, the metropolis has decided to complete the remaining works on its own," said Maharjan.

Sabita Neupane, an archaeological officer at the Department of Archaeology, said that the Department of Archaeology has not been able to decide on the extension of the term of the users' committee due to the lack of law.

The Rato Machhindranath temple located in Ward No. 22 of Lalipur Metropolis, was destroyed by the devastating earthquake of 2015. When most of the other temples and monuments damaged by the quake had already been rebuilt, the reconstruction of the Rato Machhindranath temple was unnecessarily delayed.

Are juveniles permitted for...

The authorities in Nepal don't have the information about the trekking agency that recommended the child for the EBC. The permission for trekking is issued on the recommendation of the trekking agency.

Nilhari Bastola, President of TAAN, said that they were looking for the company that recommended for the permission which would take a couple of days.

"The TAAN doesn't suggest any member companies to recommend a minor for high-altitude trekking. But there is no law to check this," he said while adding, "Since the issue was never in discussion in Nepal and abroad, trekking agencies believed on what the guardians of the children said to them."

According to the rules, a person should be at least 16 years of age to climb mountains above 5,800 metres (19,028.8 feet). Mountains with lower heights are considered as trekking peak, said Rakesh Gurung, Director of Adventure Tourism and Mountaineering Section at the Department of Tourism (DoT).

So, as per this rule, the base camps of the high peaks fall under the trekking product for which there is no age limit, this allows the trekkers to make decisions about their companions. According to Gurung, the government has not been strict about issuing permission for the trekkers who want to go for EBC or ABC trek.

"However, this trend of taking small kids to such a high altitude just for the sake of making records does no good," he said.

Had there been any untoward incidents during the child's trek to the EBC, there would have been much negative publicity of Nepal, trekking entrepreneurs said.

Meanwhile, the TAAN is mulling over an idea of writing to the federal Tourism Ministry suggesting for a need of a guideline on the age or other concerned factors for the trekkers going for high altitude area such as the EBC.

"We will also suggest the trek operators not to take such risks," said Bastola.

NEWS BRIEF

Parliamentary delegation meets Indian Minister

Kathmandu: A delegation of Nepali lawmakers which is currently in India visit had a meeting with Minister of External Affairs of India, S Jaishankar in New Delhi on Friday.

The delegation led by Chair of International Relations and Tourism Committee, Raj Kishor Yadav, had the meeting with Jaishankar, according to Indian Embassy in Nepal. Issues as bilateral relations, mutual cooperation and interests were discussed during the meeting, Indian Minister Jaishankar wrote in social media.

The Nepali lawmaker's delegation left here for India at the invitation of Lok Sabha, India three days back.

Nepali peacekeeper dies in Lebanon

Kathmandu: A Nepali soldier who was on a peacekeeping mission under the United Nations in Lebanon has died.

According to the Directorate of Public Relations and Information of the Nepali Army Headquarters on Friday, soldier Subash Thapa, working in the 64th contingent under Shree Purano Gorakh Battalion stationed in Lebanon, died on February 1.

Soldier Thapa, who was a permanent resident of Dolakha, was on standby duty in the bunker of the Battalion Headquarters and the incident happened when he was shot by a weapon he was carrying, the army said.

"He died after being found injured and taken to UNIFIL Level-1 Hospital for treatment," the army said in a statement issued on Friday.

According to the army, they are coordinating to bring his body to Nepal. (TRN/RSS)

Sita's passion and determination propel her to success

BY RENUKA DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 2

Sita Subedi, crowned as Ms. Nepal International 2023, stands as an epitome of inspiration.

A one-legged classical dancer and a gold medalist in 2018, she is not only a symbol of talent but also proof of resilience. Having triumphed over cancer, Subedi has become an inspiration to people believing in their dreams despite battling physical disability.

An energetic, bobbly girl possessing strong willpower, Sita passionately dreamt of becoming a dancer from a young age. However, fate subjected her to a formidable trial when she was just 12 years old, she lost one of her legs to cancer.

Born in 1985 to father Balkrishna Subedi and mother Saraswoti Subedi in Meghauli, Chitwan, she was fond of cycling. During a Dashain festival, she cycled carrying her siblings, which caused pressure on her legs. When her leg started swelling, her parents took her to Bharatpur Cancer Hospital. Initially, they thought it was normal swelling and would be cured after medication.

Subedi's world turned upside down after she saw the report. The doctor said that she had Osteosarcoma, a kind of bone cancer, and to save her life, one of her legs should be amputated.

She initially denied it, but her uncle said, " If you live, you will see the world," which deeply impacted her. With the belief in seeing the beautiful world, she allowed her leg to be amputated. When asked about her mental state during her cancer treatment, she said that entering her teenage years meant dealing with a high dose of cancer medication. Because of this, she didn't experience the typical hormonal changes while she shifted from childhood to adolescence.

She said that chemotherapy and high doses of medication led to her getting her period at the age of 19, and her periods were irregular.

"I missed the transition from childhood to teenage years."

During her medication, she continued her studies and successfully passed SLC exam. After SLC, she came to Bharatpur to continue her studies and started her 10+2 education at Birendra Multiple Campus. She lived alone in Bharatpur and, for financial support, she sewed clothes using one leg.

Initially, her family was not happy with their daughter's enthusiasm for dancing. The prevailing societal belief deterred an amputee like her from believing in her dreams.

She did not receive much encouragement from her family to pursue her interests.

When she realised that staying at home would hinder her studies and pursuit of her dream, she decided to shift and started living in Bharatpur.

While attending college, she enrolled in Narayani Kala Mandir Bharatpur, where she pursued her passion for dance. However, her initial experience was disheartening as a dance instructor tried to demoralise her, saying that individuals with two legs weren't accomplishing much through dance, and what could she achieve with only one leg?

This comment deeply wounded her. Then, she decided to explore music and received training from Kishor Tiwari.

Following her completion of 10+2, she moved to Kathmandu and enrolled at Padma Kanya Multiple Campus. Despite her initial desire to pursue studies in dance and music, she was not allowed to pursue these subjects.

As soon as she relocated to Kathmandu, she called her siblings, shouldering the responsibilities of supporting them.

Bearing the weight of these additional responsibilities, she started working in travel agencies. Unfortunately, juggling work and education took a toll on her academic performance, leading to weak results.

She dropped out of college. After a 10-year gap and witnessing Sita's passion for dance and study, her brother told her to resume her studies, and he would support her.

She joined Padma Kanya Campus for a Bachelor's in music and Nepali as well as Kalanidhi Indira Sangeet Mahavidyalaya for classical dance. She studied music in the morning at PK Campus and dance in the evening.

In 2018, she earned a gold medal in classical dance. She continued her academic journey by pursuing a master's degree in Nepali and music.

She wanted to elevate her beauty and intelligence, fueled by a dream of walking the runway and participating in beauty pageants. But, when she approached the beauty pageant organisers, she faced humiliation and the organisers doubted the beauty of a woman with a prosthetic leg.



Sita Subedi

Despite encountering humiliation and rejection, she cultivated a resilient self-esteem. In 2022, she confidently swaggered down the fashion runway, donning 6-inch heels.

She requested the organisers of Mrs. Nepal, and they allowed her to participate in the competition. With dedication, hard work, and confidence, she won the MS. Nepal International' and the 'Management Choice Award' in the same competition.

She is now preparing to participate in the 'Ms. International World', which will be held in Singapore in March.

She plans to promote tourism and an inclusive voice, showcasing Nepali culture in the international pageant, including Nepali classical dance.

She would be the first differently-abled South Asian woman to participate in an international beauty pageant.

Six receive Kalashree awards



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu. Feb. 2

Veteran short story writer Bhagirathi Shrestha has been honoured with National Kalashree Award-2080 for her outstanding contribution to Nepali short stories. The award carries a purse of Rs. 100,000.

Five other personalities in the art and literature field were also honoured with different awards at a function organised by the Nepali Art And Literature Dot Com Foundation in the capital on Thursday.

Poet Krisu Chhetri, artist Samjhana Rajbhandari, literary journalist and editor-in-chief of literary online Sahityapost Ashwini Koirala and promising musician Santosh Shrestha were honoured with Sasiddhi Rastriya Kala Shree Youth Award, Rastriya Kala Shree Fine Art Award, Badri Rastriya Kala Shree Journalism Award and Padmanetra Rastriya Kala Shree Music Award respectively.

It was mentioned that they were honoured for their significant contribution to their respective field. Chhetri and Rajbhandari received a purse of Rs. Rs. 75,000 and Rs. 60,000 respectively while Koirala and Shrestha got Rs. 50,000 each.

The awards are presented annually by the Nepali Art And Literature Dot Com Foundation.

Likewise, Rastriya Kala Shree Felicitation was conferred on senior film director, lyricist and satirist Yadav Kharel in hounour of his outstanding contribution to the field of film and literature. However he was not present at the function due to his illness. It was informed that the honour would be presented to him when he would get well. The foundation wished him speedy recovery at the function. Prior to this, this felicitation was conferred on Jagadish Ghimire, Madan Mani Dixit, Satya Mohan Joshi, Shashi Shah, Phatte Man Rajbhandari, Manuj Babu Mishra, Tulsi Diwas, Durga Baral, Durgalal Shrestha, Dr. Basudev Tripathy, Bairagi Kaila, Prem Dhwoj Pradhan, Raamesh, Parashu Pradhan and Kiran Manandhar.

Senior artist and former chancellor of Nepal Fine Art Academy Kiran Manandhar handed over the awards.

Applauding the organisers' efforts, Manandhar stressed the need for cooperation between artists and authors. He encouraged the organisers to come up with spectacular programmes that bring artists and authors to the same stage.

Young critic Mahesh Paudyal highlighted the personalities, contributions and background of all the honoured persons while chief patron of the Foundation Dr. Bimal Koirala and vice-chairman Rajeshwore Karki spoke about the activities of the Foundation.

Chairperson of the Foundation Momila Joshi, who is also a popular poet, essayist as well as active literary activist, said that the goal of the Foundation was only to honour the right persons and recognise their contributions.

Actress-model Poonam Pandey succumbs to cancer

AGENCIES
Mumbai, Feb. 2



Indian model-cum-actress Poonam Pandey succumbed to cancer at 32, her media team said here on Friday.

"This morning is a tough one for us. Deeply saddened to inform you that we have lost our beloved Poonam to cervical cancer. Every living form that ever came in contact with her was met with pure love and kindness.In this time of grief, we would request for privacy, while we remember her fondly for all that we shared," said a statement today."

No details of Pandey's passing, where and when, or whether any of her family members were present, are provided in the message. She was seen in Bigg Boss (2011), and then made her Bollywood debut in 2013 with the film "Nasha", "GST - Galti Sirf Tumhari" (2017), and a few other films and television serials.

In 2011, she grabbed headlines by promising to strip for the Indian cricket team if it bagged the Cricket World Cup that year, and similar such daredevilry on various occasions.

Memoir on Krishna Prakash Shrestha released

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 2



Nepal Russia Society of Literature has come up with Samjhana Ko Tarelima Krishna Prakash Shrestha (Late Krishna Prakash in the Wave of Memories), a collection of memoirs in Nepali by 30 authors.

Late Shrestha was the pioneer translator who translated great Russian books in Nepali such as Mother and three autobiographical novels by Maxim Gorky, The Fate Of A Man And Stories of Don by Mikhail Sholokov and many philosophical books by the Russian writers. He translated the great works by Nepali authors such as Muna Madan into Russian. He had passed away on March 29, 2021.

The book was released at a function organised by the Nepal Russia Society of Literature at the Russian House in Kathmandu. Edited by Dr. Jangab Chauhan, Chandra Kant Acharya, Vishnu Bahadur Singh and Ram Bindu Shrestha, the book consists of memoirs by Tej Prakash Shrestha, Nilamber Acharya, Dr. Jangab Chauhan, Pradeep Gyawali, Ganga Prasad Upreti, Dr. Usha Thakur, Egor Elisiev, Dr. Shyam Upadhayay, Basanta Thapa, Jiba Lamichhane, Dr. Arjun Dev Bhatta, Manjul, Dr. Khem Koirala Bandhu, Kiran Karki, Ashesh Malla, Tarabadan Shrestha, Shyamal Adhikary, Dr. Madhu Madhurya and Bikram Subba.

Likewise, memoirs by Bishnu Bahadur Singh, Indira Prasai, Dr. Bhisma Acharya, Kanhaiya Nasnani, Chandra Kanta Acharya, Ram Bindu Shrestha, Jivan Ojha, Dr. Amod Mani Dixit, Narendra Raj Prasai and Mohan Duwal are also included in the book. Moreover, a memoir by Krishna Prakash Shrestha himself titled Banasurko Rajdhani Shonitpurko Yatra is also included in the anthology in which he argues that Thankot of Kathmandu district is the Shonitpur which was the capital city of Asur King Banasur.

At the programme, diplomat and classmate of Shrestha at Moscow State University Nilamber Acharya opined that the translation of Nepali and Russian literature in each other language was a real felicitation to the late Shrestha.

Other speakers including journalist Basanta Thapa, Khem Koirala Bandhu, Rajendra Bahadur Bhandari, Dr. Basudev Tripathi, Jungab Chauhan, Amod Mani Dixit, Chandra Kanta Acharya and Bishnu Bahadur Singh also shed light on the late Shrestha's contribution to the field of translations and original creations. The book is published by the Nepal Russia Society of Literature.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: A seemingly impulsive financial decision could bring you closer to a significant goal. Sometimes you just need to get out of a frustrating rut in any way you can -- even if it isn't tidy.

TAURUS: Standing up to someone who seeks to tie you down might be necessary at the moment. The clear reality that you can't always protect everyone else's feelings while doing what you need to do could challenge your beliefs.

GEMINI: Hidden resentment could provoke you to impulsively shirk your ongoing duties. This pain is a valid signal that change is necessary. Perhaps distributing responsibilities more fairly with someone else involved in the situation.

CANCER: Your current eagerness to build relationships could come off a little too anxious. While the spontaneous Moon in your 5th House of Self-Expression opposes volatile Uranus in your social 11th house.

LEO: Pursuing a goal outside your comfort zone could rattle your sense of security now. That doesn't mean you shouldn't go for it! While the anxious Moon in your sensitive 4th house reaches out to both clever Mercury.

VIRGO: A craving for attention could be burning a hole in your inhibitions at the moment. When the impulsive Moon in your communication zone goads wild Uranus in your adventurous 9th house.

LIBRA: Feeling anxious about your finances could tempt you to make a last-minute, rash decision. While the fretful Moon in your money zone nags impatient Uranus.

SCORPIO: You may currently feel vulnerable because someone you rely on seems unstable. Can you tell them that without being mean about it? Although being angry is understandable, you can communicate your concerns.

SAGITTARIUS: Your current need for rest could motivate you to look for a way out of an oppressive responsibility. While the mellow Moon in your 12th House of Contemplation soothes driven Mars in your finance sector.

CAPRICORN: Intimidating your peers is possible at this time. While the impressionable Moon in your social zone takes notice of both brilliant Mercury and bombastic Mars in your sign.

AQUARIUS: Your hidden feelings could become known without warning -- but it shouldn't be the end of the world! As the emotional Moon in your public 10th house sextiles articulate Mercury in your 12th House of Secrets.

PISCES: Taking a routine conversation in an unexpected direction could be tempting now. While the inquisitive Moon in your philosophical 9th house provokes unstable Uranus in your communication zone.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Nepal wraps up U19 World Cup with loss to India

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 2



PHOTO: ICC

Dev Khanal of Nepal plays a shot during the ICC U19 Men's Cricket World Cup Super Six match against India in Bloemfontein, South Africa on Friday.

Winning in a nail-biting do-or-die match against Afghanistan's young side during the group stage and qualifying for the Super Six, Nepal's younguns expanded their stay in South Africa. The team's extended campaign ended after losing against India in its final match of the Super Six Group A on Friday.

Nepal, an associate team, defeated Afghanistan, a Test-playing nation, and became the only associate member to progress to the Super Six. The win against Afghanistan was the only victory for Nepal's U19 team in five matches throughout the campaign. In the other four matches, which were against New Zealand, Pakistan, Bangladesh and India, Nepal's future stars could only gain experience. Nepal was however able to create at least one moment where it dominated quality opponents in the four matches it lost.

Such a moment was created twice, while bowling first and later in the chase, by Nepal at Mangaung Oval in Bloemfontein, South Africa, against five-time U19 World Cup winners India.

Nepal had the barest of chances for the semi-finals based on points despite qualifying for the Super Six. Moreover, the wins for India and Pakistan in their opening matches of the Super Six ended the hopes for not only Nepal but other teams in the group. India, who is also the defending champion, lost its first three wickets by the end of the 14th at only 62 runs. At that moment, Nepali cricket fans saw a chance to restrict India to a low total and chase it howsoever. Similarly, Nepali openers stayed not out until 13.2 overs with 48 runs on the board. It was the first time in the tournament that India was unable to take three wickets of the opponent within the first powerplay.

However, both moments were crushed by the high-quality Indian side. From 62/3, India U19 captain Uday Saharan and Sachin Dhas took the team to 277 runs before Dhas departed in 47.4 overs. Both registered individual centuries with Saharan departing at 100 off 107 and Dhas at 116 off 101. With Musheer Khan adding nine more runs, India posted a target of 298 in the loss of five wickets.

Gulshan Jha took three wickets and Aakash Chand claimed one for Nepal. India's Priyanshu Moliya was run out while trying to run for the fifth run.

On the other hand, Indian bowlers were unable to send either of the openers Deepak Bohora and Arjun Kumal back to the pavilion within the first powerplay. While the first wicket fell after a long time than India expected, the others did not take time.

With Bohora departing at 22 off 42 in the 14th over when the team was at 48/1, Nepal lost its next six wickets until the 28th over. Dipesh Kandel departed as the seventh wicket without opening his account leaving Nepal at 77/7 in 27.5 overs. By then, Uttam Magar, Arjun Kumal, Bishal Bikram KC and Deepak Dumre departed at 8 off 30, 22 off 42, 1 off 2 and 0 off 4 respectively.

Gulshan Jha, who already had enough experience playing in the senior team, was again unable to deliver with the bat. Similar to the previous four matches in the campaign, Jha departed for a paltry, this time at 1 off 6.

Captain Dev Khanal showed determination with Subash Bhandari, a bowler who has proved with the bat by stealing runs coming at the tail-end, stayed at the crease, rotated strikes, and took Nepal over the 100-run mark. Bhandari, however, departed as the eighth wicket leaving Nepal at 105-8 by the end of the 35th over.

Khanal departed in the 39th over leaving Nepal at 120/9 after adding 33 off 53. The last two batsmen, Aakash Chand and Durgesh Gupta, whom India expected to send back ASAP became the biggest headache as they batted until the 50 overs for a record last-wicket partnership for the team. Nepal was 165/9 by the end of the batting inning.

Gupta, with the only six for Nepal, became the second-highest scorer in the game with 29 off 43 alongside Chand (18 off 35) and stayed not out despite the team falling short of 132 runs.

Saumy Pandey bagged four wickets while Arshin Kulkarni took two. Likewise, Raj Limbani, Aaradhya Shukla and Murugan Abhishek claimed one each for India. India progresses to the semi-final stage as the topper of Super Six Group A after the win against Nepal.

Nation cheers as Sabitra joins French club Guingamp

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Feb. 2



PHOTO: EAG'S WEBSITE

Nepal's forward Sabitra Bhandari 'Samba' signs for En Avant Guingamp, a club playing at Arkema D1, the highest division of women's football in France.

It was known: Sabitra Bhandari aka Samba is built for top-tier football. And, now Samba has proved it as she has signed for En Avant Guingamp, a club playing at Arkema D1, the highest division of women's football in France.

En Avant Guingamp (EAG) made the signing public through its Facebook page (En Avant Guingamp Féminines) when it was midnight in Nepal. Since early Friday morning, social media has flooded with admiration for Samba as she progresses forward in football.

"Bhandari becomes the first every Nepali player to play for a top-tier European club," All Nepal Football Association wrote on its website.

Samba became the first Nepali player to play professional football in Europe through Israel's Hapoel Ra'anana Football Club in 2023; however, she returned halfway after the war.

Now, wearing jersey number 28, Samba will play in France, a greater platform than Israel, against teams such as Olympique Lyonnais (Lyon) and Paris Saint-Germain (PSG).

As the UEFA Women's Champions League 2023-24 group stage matches between 16 teams divided into four groups have now come to an end, Lyon and PSG stay at the top of groups B and C respectively.

EAG has signed Samba until June 2024 with an option to extend the contract by a year. EAG is currently in the 10th position at the table among 12 teams. The club has earned 8 points in 12 matches with two wins, two draws and eight losses. A team plays 22 matches each in Arkema D1.

Samba seems ready

Samba has conquered every platform she has set her foot on. She is the all-time highest scorer for Nepal with 43 goals in 42 games for the national team.

Playing in Nepal's domestic league for the Armed Police Force Club, Samba started her international club career in India.

She signed for Sethu FC and debuted in the Indian Women's League from the season 2018-19. Scoring two goals in the final match of the season against Manipur Police SC, Samba helped Sethu FC win its maiden trophy.

In the next season, Samba got associated with Gokulam Kerala FC and helped the club lift the trophy twice, in 2019-20 and 2022-23, and was the league's highest scorer in both seasons. In 2022-23, Samba was the highest scorer with 29 goals. In the three seasons in India, Samba scored 59 goals.

In June 2023, Samba started her professional career in European football at Israel's Hapoel Ra'anana FC. She scored four goals in her debut match defeating Ramat Hasharon 4-0. The goals continued coming from Samba's boot until she returned after the Gaza-Israel conflict.

Informing of the past achievements of Samba on its website, EVG seems extremely happy with the signing as the team looks forward to staying in better positions than the current one in the league. According to Samba, she too looks forward to continuing her form in top-tier football.

"Thank you for all your well wishes…..as we begin an exciting journey with EA Guingamp. I feel proud to represent my nation in the stage I've always dreamed of…..This new journey is exciting as well as challenging at the same time. And I hope to continue the same path in this too," Samba wrote on her Facebook while thanking the well-wishers for her new journey in France.

Samba's new team faces Bordeaux in the league at Nepali time at 7:15 pm on Saturday. Whether Samba will debut for the team against Bordeaux or not is still unknown.

SNIPPETS

Bartlett earns Australia big win

Melbourne (AFP): Fast bowler Xavier Bartlett took 4-17 in his ODI debut as Australia thrashed West Indies by eight wickets with 69 balls remaining in their series opener on Friday. Josh Inglis showed little signs of testing positive for COVID-19 the day before when he smacked a quick-fire 65 off 43 balls for Australia. Asked to bat first, West Indies was eventually bowled out for 231 in 48.4 overs after Bartlett's stunning three-wicket opening burst had left the tourists in trouble at 59-4 as he went on to record Australia's second-best ODI figures on debut. Captain Steven Smith (79 not out) and Cameroon Green (77 not out) struck fine unbeaten half centuries as Australia eased to 232-2 in 38.3 overs.

Joselu double sends Madrid top

Getafe (AFP): Joselu struck twice as Real Madrid strolled into first place in La Liga with a comfortable 2-0 win at Getafe on Thursday. Carlo Ancelotti's side are two points clear of shock title challengers Girona after a catch-up fixture which means both sides have played 22 matches. Striker Joselu, on loan from Espanyol, headed Madrid in front in the first half and finished lethally early in the second to put his team in command against their mid-table opposition. Madrid lead rivals Atletico Madrid, third, and Barcelona, fourth, by 10 points. They face Diego Simeone's Atletico on Sunday at the Santiago Bernabeu.

Mainoo saves ManU blushes

London (AFP): Kobbie Mainoo scored a 97th-minute winner as Manchester United snatched a dramatic 4-3 win at Wolves on Thursday after blowing a two-goal lead.

Marcus Rashford's goalscoring return, days after being fined for missing training after a night out, looked set to grab the headlines as United raced into a 2-0 lead. Scott McTominay restored the visitors' two-goal cushion after Pablo Sarabia's penalty got Wolves back in the game. But the home side looked to have claimed a point when Max Kilman and Pedro Neto struck late on. However, 18-year-old Mainoo provided one final twist with a brilliant solo run and shot in the latest display of his potential as a rising star. Ten Hag's men can move into the top six on Sunday when they host West Ham after the Hammers were held 1-1 at home to Bournemouth.

Ton-up Jaiswal anchors India to 336-6

AP
Visakhapatnam, Feb. 2



Opener Yashasvi Jaiswal hit an unbeaten 179 as India took opening day honours in the second Test despite regular England strikes, including debutant Shoaib Bashir's two wickets, on Friday.

India, who trail the five-match series 1-0, reached 336-6 at stumps with the left-handed Jaiswal and Ravichandran Ashwin, on five, batting in Visakhapatnam.

Bashir and fellow spinner Rehan Ahmed took two wickets each.

Bashir, 20, got skipper Rohit Sharma as his first Test wicket and pace bowler James Anderson made it two down before Jaiswal hit back.

Jaiswal took on the England spinners to smash Tom Hartley for three successive boundaries and set the pace.

He reached his second Test ton with a six off Hartley and removed his helmet, raised his arms and blew a kiss to the cheering crowd.

It was India's first century in the series. England's Ollie Pope hit 196 in the opening Test.

Jaiswal kept up the attack and India dominated the final hour of play despite losing Axar Patel and hometown hero K.S. Bharat.

The 22-year-old Jaiswal, playing his sixth Test, smashed 17 fours and five sixes to surpass his previous Test best of 171 on debut in the West Indies last year.

Bashir got Axar caught at backward point for his second wicket as he bowled disciplined spells to showcase his variety and guile in just his seventh first-class match.

The bowler was a late arrival in India after a visa delay -- the latest cricketer of Pakistani descent to have such troubles in India -- and missed the series opener.

Debutant Rajat Patidar made 32 before being bowled by Ahmed as the batsman's forward defensive stroke saw the ball, with backspin, roll onto the stumps.

Hartley, who returned figures of 7-62 in England's 28-run win in Hyderabad, had sent back Shreyas Iyer for 27 against the run of play in the second session.

Earlier, Jaiswal and Rohit started cautiously to drive the hosts to 40-0 in the first hour of play before Bashir broke through in the second over after the drinks break.

Bashir got Rohit caught out for 14 at leg-slip on a delivery that turned sharply into the right-hander.

Anderson had Shubman Gill caught behind for 34 as the 41-year-old veteran moved to 691 Test wickets.

India are looking to bounce back in the series after losing just their fourth Test since 2013.

Jordan books historical semi-final berth at Asian Cup

AFC
Al Rayyan, Feb. 2



A Vahdat Hanonov own goal was enough to send Jordan to the AFC Asian Cup Qatar 2023™ semi-finals for the first time in their history, following a 1-0 victory over Tajikistan at Ahmad bin Ali Stadium on Friday.

The West Asian nation had reached the quarter-finals twice, losing to Japan in 2004 and to Uzbekistan in 2011, while Tajikistan's maiden continental adventure ends at the quarter-finals after a series of heroic performances in Qatar 2023.

Jordanian goalkeeper Yazeed Abulaila was left watching in fear as the ball bounced off the crossbar after Ehson Panjshanbe was first to poke Shervoni Mabatshoev's low cross from the right. Tajikistan suffered a blow when forward Shahrom Samiev had to hobble off the pitch in tears following a hamstring injury, to be replaced by Rustam Soirov before the half-hour mark.

The first big Jordanian chance arrived a minute later when Mahmoud Al Mardi curled an in-swinging cross from the left flank towards the far post where Yazan Al Nuaimat lurked, but the forward's attempted finish saw the ball hitting the side netting.

Coach Petar Segrt's men were gifted a scoring chance on a silver platter seven minutes into the second half when left-back Salem Al Ajalin failed to deal with the ball, allowing Mabatshoev to snatch the ball and advance into the box, but with just the goalkeeper to beat, he fluffed his lines under pressure from defender Yazan Al Arab.

The deadlock was finally broken midway through the second half when defender Abdullah Nasib rose highest to head Ehsan Haddad's delivery from the corner, and his header bounced off Tajik defender Vahdat Hanonov before settling in the back of the net for Jordan's opener.

Jordan nearly doubled their lead two minutes later when a quick counter attack saw Yazan Al Nuaimat dance his way past two Tajik players before squaring for Al Taamari who had the goal at his mercy but sent his shot from 11 yards wide and high.

Coach Hussein Ammouta's men will face the winners of the Australia and Korea Republic in the semi-finals on Tuesday.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:50 am, Sunset at 5:46 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 17 - 19°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	21.4	7.7	0.4
Dadeldhura	13.1	0.7	0.0
Dhangadi	23.2	7.2	0.0
Birendranagar	20.8	9.0	0.3
Nepalgunj	23.2	6.4	0.0
Jumla	11.5	-5.9	0.0
Ghorahi	21.4	6.0	0.0
Pokhara	19.6	6.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	25.2	7.0	0.0
Simara	24.8	9.5	0.0
Kathmandu	18.5	4.8	0.5
Okhaldhunga	16.2	4.9	0.0
Taplejung	14.5	5.9	0.4
Dhankuta	19.0	9.5	0.0
Biratnagar	24.6	10.0	0.0
Jomsom	7.1	-6.5	Traces*
Dharan	24.0	13.0	0.0*
Lumle	14.0	2.5	0.0*
Janakpur	27.4	10.0	0.0*
Jiri	14.4	-1.1	1.1*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 3, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.38	Rs. 132.98
Euro	1	Rs. 144.07	Rs. 144.72
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.91	Rs. 169.68
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 154.71	Rs. 155.41
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.44	Rs. 87.84
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.97	Rs. 99.42
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.14	Rs. 99.59
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.03	Rs. 9.08
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.44	Rs. 18.53
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.30	Rs. 35.46
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.31	Rs. 36.48
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.76	Rs. 3.78
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.04	Rs. 36.20
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.07	Rs. 28.19
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.00	Rs. 10.04
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.77	Rs. 12.83
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.33	Rs. 19.42
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.93	Rs. 17.01
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.83	Rs. 432.78
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.17	Rs. 352.76

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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